Teacher Metacognitive Practices in Advanced Academic Courses: A Look at Bias and Pereption

A Pilot Study Conducted by

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for EDF 625: Qualitative Research
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Abstract

The Abstract is the absolute last thing you write. In the abstract, write a concise summary of the key points of your research. (Do not indent.) Your abstract clearly state that it is a pilot study and should contain at least your research topic, research questions or approach if questions haven't been identified yet, participants, methods, results, and discussion (including specific discussion with how you modify the study based on pilot data). You may also include possible implications of your research and future work you see connected with your findings. Your abstract should be a single paragraph, double-spaced. Your abstract should be between 150 and 250 words.

Example:

This pilot study used an ethnographic framework to explore the lived experiences of teachers integrating technology in a rural, Appalachian middle school. A series of participant observations of grade 3 and 5 classrooms were conducted as well as semi-structured interviews of 3 teachers and 2 administrators at the school. Thematic analysis was conducted and in vivo coding techniques were used to analyze data. Results suggest three primary themes in the data. The first theme, *We built the plane while we flew it* identifies how learning occurred through the tumultuous integration effort. The second theme, *You gotta have friends* acknowledges how the sharing the burden of the integration effort supported their learning. Finally, the third theme, *It was okay to fail* describes how feelings of administrator support made the teachers more comfortable taking risks in the classroom. Findings from the pilot informed substantive changes to the interview protocol and suggest that research questions for the regular study should focus on the area of administrator support to determine how best to encourage lasting technology integration in the classroom.

Introduction

In recent years, there has been a growing acknowledgment of the significance of metacognitive practices in the field of education, particularly in advanced academic programs like Advanced Placement (AP) and International Baccalaureate (IB). Metacognition, which refers to the awareness and self-regulation of one's learning processes, has been proven to enhance student performance by fostering deeper comprehension and improved retention of material (Owen & Vista, 2017). Despite the documented benefits, the utilization of metacognitive strategies by educators in advanced academic settings varies widely and is often influenced by factors such as school demographics and teacher perceptions. The aim of this preliminary study is to investigate the implementation of metacognitive teaching strategies among educators in advanced academic courses within different school settings, specifically, Title I schools serving underserved minority populations and schools in higher socioeconomic status (SES) areas with predominantly white student populations. The study seeks to determine whether there are significant discrepancies in the adoption and frequency of metacognitive practices between these two settings. Additionally, it aims to examine how teachers' perceptions of student capabilities may impact their utilization of these strategies.

Previous research has underscored the influence of teacher bias on student outcomes, particularly for minority and economically disadvantaged students. For example, Kao and Zimmermann (2020) discovered that teachers' perceptions of student capabilities are often influenced by race and gender, resulting in lower expectations and reduced academic support for minority students. Similarly, Leslie et al. (2015) emphasized the necessity of interventions to address teacher biases in STEM education to promote equity and enhance student performance.

This pilot study will involve observation and interviewing of educators in both Title I and higher socioeconomic status schools to assess their use of metacognitive strategies. The observations will focus on classroom practices, aiming to capture the real-time application of these strategies. The interviews, on the other hand, will delve into teachers' perceptions of their students' abilities and their reasoning behind the application or non-application of specific metacognitive techniques. By comparing these findings across different school settings, this study aims to shed light on potential disparities in metacognitive teaching practices and their implications for student learning, thereby providing valuable insights for future educational policies and practices.

Literature Review

Metacognitive Practices in Education

Metacognition is “thinking about one's thinking” and involves processes used to plan, monitor, and assess one's understanding and performance (Chick, 2023). It encompasses a critical awareness of oneself as a thinker and learner and is essential for deep learning and developing higher-order thinking skills (Taylor, 2021). Research has shown that metacognitive practices increase students' abilities to transfer or adapt their learning to new contexts and tasks by gaining awareness above the subject matter (Chen, 2020).

The Role of Metacognition in Learning

Metacognitive practices are integral to effective learning. According to Schraw and Dennison (1994), metacognitive awareness includes three components: declarative knowledge (knowledge about oneself as a learner and about what factors influence one's performance), procedural knowledge (knowledge about strategies and processes), and conditional knowledge (knowledge about when and why to use strategies). These components enable students to effectively plan, monitor, and evaluate their learning processes.

Studies have demonstrated that metacognitive strategies enhance students' problem-solving skills, decision-making abilities, and critical thinking (Pintrich, 2002). For instance, a study by Dignath and Büttner (2008) found that teaching metacognitive strategies in elementary and secondary schools significantly improved students' academic performance. Similarly, Haller, Child, and Walberg (1988) reported that metacognitive training positively influenced reading comprehension and mathematical problem-solving skills.

Metacognitive practices not only improve academic performance but also foster the development of self-regulated learning. Self-regulated learners are those who actively set goals, monitor their progress, and adjust their strategies to achieve their objectives (Zimmerman & Schunk, 2001). These learners are better equipped to handle complex and challenging tasks, demonstrating higher levels of resilience and persistence.

Teacher Bias and Its Impact on Metacognitive Practices

Implementing metacognitive practices in classrooms is significantly affected by teacher perceptions and biases. Teachers' beliefs about their students' abilities can profoundly influence their instructional methods and how much they engage students in metacognitive activities. Research indicates that in lower-income, underserved schools, teachers often face challenges impacting their ability to engage students in metacognitive work. These challenges include larger class sizes, limited resources, and the pressure to meet standardized testing benchmarks (Lehmann et al., 2022). Consequently, teachers in these settings may underestimate their students' abilities, focusing more on rote learning and test preparation rather than fostering metacognitive skills (Kao & Zimmermann, 2020; Leslie et al., 2015).

Whether implicit or explicit, teacher bias plays a crucial role in shaping classroom dynamics and instructional strategies. Studies have shown that teachers' expectations of students' abilities often align with students' socioeconomic status, race, and gender, leading to differentiated instruction that may disadvantage certain groups. For instance, Tenenbaum and Ruck (2007) found that teachers interacted more favorably with students they perceived as high achievers, often providing them with more opportunities for higher-order thinking and problem-solving activities. Conversely, students from marginalized backgrounds were less likely to be engaged in such practices, potentially limiting their academic growth and self-efficacy.

Implicit bias is unconscious attitudes or stereotypes that affect our understanding, actions, and decisions. These biases can influence teachers' expectations and interactions with students. For example, teachers may unknowingly lower their expectations for students from certain racial or socioeconomic backgrounds, which can impact their academic performance and engagement (Glock & Krolak-Schwerdt, 2013). This phenomenon underscores the importance of addressing teacher biases through professional development and reflective practices.

Disparities in Metacognitive Practices

Studies have highlighted significant disparities in using metacognitive strategies between different school settings. For instance, teachers in higher socioeconomic status (SES) schools, with predominantly white student populations are more likely to implement metacognitive practices than their counterparts in Title I schools serving underserved minority populations (Graham & Perin, 2007). This discrepancy is often attributed to the higher expectations and greater resource availability in higher SES schools, which enable teachers to focus more on metacognitive instruction (Chen, 2020).

The disparities in metacognitive practices are a matter of resource allocation but also of teacher preparedness and confidence. According to a study by Zohar and Dori (2003), teachers who received professional development in metacognitive instruction were more likely to integrate these strategies into their teaching, regardless of their school's SES. This finding suggests that targeted training and support can mitigate some of the disparities observed in different educational settings.

Furthermore, the school environment plays a critical role in shaping teachers' ability to implement metacognitive strategies. Schools with supportive leadership, collaborative professional communities, and access to instructional resources are more likely to foster environments where metacognitive practices can thrive (Fullan, 2011). Conversely, schools facing challenges such as high teacher turnover, limited professional development opportunities, and inadequate resources may struggle to sustain effective metacognitive instruction.

Impact of Teacher Training on Metacognitive Practices

Teacher training and professional development are crucial in equipping educators with the skills and knowledge necessary to implement metacognitive strategies effectively. Programs focusing on metacognitive instruction and culturally responsive pedagogy can help teachers recognize and overcome their biases, thereby improving their ability to engage all students in higher-order thinking (Owen & Vista, 2017). Studies have shown that when teachers are trained to use metacognitive strategies, they are better able to help students become aware of their strengths and weaknesses, plan their learning, and monitor their progress (Chen, 2020).

Professional development programs emphasizing reflective practice and metacognitive awareness can significantly enhance teachers' instructional methods. For instance, a study by Wilson and Bai (2010) found that teachers who engaged in professional development focused on metacognitive strategies reported increased confidence in their ability to teach these skills and observed positive changes in their students' learning behaviors. Additionally, the implementation of professional learning communities (PLCs) has been shown to support teachers in sharing best practices and collaboratively developing metacognitive instructional techniques (Vescio, Ross, & Adams, 2008).

Effective teacher training programs should also address the role of culturally responsive pedagogy in metacognitive instruction. Culturally responsive teaching practices recognize and value students' cultural backgrounds, making learning more relevant and engaging. By incorporating students' cultural references into metacognitive activities, teachers can foster a more inclusive learning environment that encourages all students to engage in higher-order thinking (Ladson-Billings, 1995).

Culturally Responsive Pedagogy and Metacognition

Culturally responsive pedagogy, which emphasizes the importance of recognizing and valuing students' cultural backgrounds in the learning process, can enhance the effectiveness of metacognitive instruction. Ladson-Billings (1995) argued that culturally responsive teaching practices not only affirm students' cultural identities but also promote higher academic achievement by making learning more relevant and engaging. By incorporating students' cultural references into metacognitive activities, teachers can foster a more inclusive learning environment that encourages all students to engage in higher-order thinking.

Research has shown that culturally responsive pedagogy can mitigate some of the negative impacts of teacher bias on student engagement. For example, a study by Gay (2002) demonstrated that teachers who adopted culturally responsive teaching practices were more likely to employ metacognitive strategies resonating with their students' lived experiences, enhancing student motivation and academic performance. Similarly, Paris and Alim (2014) highlighted the importance of culturally sustaining pedagogy, which seeks to sustain and uplift students' cultural ways of being while promoting critical and metacognitive thinking.

Implementing culturally responsive metacognitive practices involves several strategies. Teachers can create opportunities for students to reflect on their cultural identities and experiences as part of metacognitive activities. This approach validates students' backgrounds and encourages them to draw connections between their lived experiences and academic content (Hammond, 2015). Additionally, incorporating diverse perspectives and materials into the curriculum can help students develop a more comprehensive and critical understanding of the subject matter.

Metacognition and Student Outcomes

The positive impact of metacognitive practices on student outcomes is well-documented in the literature. Students who are taught to use metacognitive strategies are better equipped to understand and manage their learning processes, leading to improved academic performance across various subjects. For instance, a meta-analysis by Hattie (2009) found that metacognitive strategies had a significant effect size of 0.69 on student achievement, indicating their substantial impact on learning outcomes.

Moreover, the benefits of metacognitive practices extend beyond academic performance. Students who develop strong metacognitive skills are likelier to exhibit greater self-efficacy, resilience, and motivation (Zimmerman & Schunk, 2001). These skills are critical for lifelong learning and success in various domains, including higher education and the workforce. For example, a study by Dignath and Büttner (2008) found that elementary and secondary students who received metacognitive training showed increased motivation and persistence in challenging tasks, suggesting that metacognitive practices foster a growth mindset and positive attitudes toward learning.

Metacognitive practices also play a crucial role in fostering critical thinking and problem-solving skills. Students who engage in metacognitive activities are more likely to analyze and evaluate information critically, leading to better decision-making and problem-solving abilities (Kuhn & Dean, 2004). This is particularly important in today's rapidly changing world, where the ability to think critically and adapt to new situations is essential for success.

Challenges and Barriers to Implementing Metacognitive Practices

Despite the well-documented benefits of metacognitive practices, several challenges and barriers hinder their widespread implementation in classrooms. One significant barrier is the lack of teacher training and support. Many teachers report feeling unprepared to teach metacognitive strategies and express a need for more professional development opportunities (Wilson & Bai, 2010). The pressure to meet standardized testing requirements can also limit teachers' ability to incorporate metacognitive instruction into their curricula, particularly in under-resourced schools.

Another challenge is the potential for teacher bias to influence implementing metacognitive practices. As previously discussed, teachers' perceptions of their students' abilities can shape their instructional methods, potentially leading to lower expectations and reduced opportunities for higher-order thinking for certain student groups (Kao & Zimmermann, 2020). Addressing these biases through professional development and culturally responsive pedagogy is essential for ensuring that all students have access to metacognitive instruction.

Additionally, systemic issues such as inadequate funding, high student-teacher ratios, and lack of access to instructional resources can impede the implementation of metacognitive practices. Schools in lower-income areas often face these challenges, making it difficult for teachers to provide the individualized support necessary for effective metacognitive instruction (Darling-Hammond, 2010).

Strategies for Overcoming Barriers

Several strategies can be employed to support the implementation of metacognitive practices in classrooms to overcome these challenges. First, comprehensive and ongoing professional development programs should be provided to equip teachers with the necessary skills and knowledge to teach metacognitive strategies effectively. These programs should include training on reflective practices, culturally responsive pedagogy, and methods for fostering self-regulated learning (Fullan, 2011).

Second, schools should establish professional learning communities (PLCs) where teachers can collaborate, share best practices, and develop metacognitive instructional techniques together. PLCs can provide a supportive environment for teachers to learn from one another and continuously improve their instructional methods (Vescio, Ross, & Adams, 2008).

Third, policymakers and educational leaders should advocate for equitable funding and resource allocation to ensure that all schools, particularly those in underserved areas, have the necessary resources to support metacognitive instruction. This includes providing access to instructional materials, technology, and support staff to assist with implementing metacognitive practices (Darling-Hammond, 2010).

Finally, fostering a school culture that values and prioritizes metacognitive practices is essential. School leaders should encourage teachers to integrate metacognitive activities into their daily instruction and provide opportunities for students to reflect on their learning processes regularly. Celebrating successes and showcasing examples of effective metacognitive instruction can help build a culture of reflective practice within the school community (Hattie, 2009).

Statement of Problem

While the literature review shows that research in the area of metacognitive practices in education has extensively addressed the importance of metacognition in enhancing student performance and self-regulated learning (Flavell, 1979; Schraw & Moshman, 1995; Zimmerman & Schunk, 2001), there is little research that focuses specifically on the implementation of these practices in Advanced Placement (AP) programs within underserved school populations. Existing studies have highlighted the disparities in the application of metacognitive strategies across different socioeconomic contexts, with a significant gap in resources and teacher preparedness affecting underserved schools (Graham & Perin, 2007; Chen, 2020; Lehmann et al., 2022). Moreover, the impact of teacher biases on the engagement of students in metacognitive activities has been identified as a critical barrier to the equitable application of these strategies (Tenenbaum & Ruck, 2007; Glock & Krolak-Schwerdt, 2013).

This pilot study aims to explore and test methods meant to help determine how best to study the gap in the literature related to the implementation of metacognitive practices in AP programs, particularly in underserved schools. By focusing on teacher training and culturally responsive pedagogy, this study will seek to understand how to effectively engage students from marginalized populations in metacognitive activities and assess the impact on their academic performance. The findings from this pilot study will provide insights into developing comprehensive strategies for integrating metacognitive practices in AP courses, addressing both the instructional and perceptual barriers that currently exist.

Methods

The study uses a mixed-methods approach, combining qualitative observations and interviews with quantitative data analysis. Specifically, it utilizes a phenomenological study design to explore the lived experiences and perceptions of teachers regarding their use of metacognitive teaching strategies. Phenomenological research focuses on understanding how individuals perceive and make sense of their experiences, making it suitable for this pilot study, which aims to delve into teachers' beliefs and practices (Moustakas, 1994).

Phenomenology is particularly appropriate for this study because it seeks to understand the essence of teachers' experiences with metacognitive strategies in different educational contexts. By capturing detailed accounts of their practices and perceptions, this approach allows for a deep exploration of the factors influencing their instructional methods.

Participants

The study will involve teachers from advanced academic courses at two types of schools: Title I schools with a predominantly minority and low SES student population, and higher SES schools with a predominantly white student population. A total of 20 teachers (10 from each type of school) will be selected based on their experience and willingness to participate. This selection aims to ensure a diverse representation of teaching practices and school environments (Graham & Perin, 2007).

Procedures

Observations: Classroom observations will be conducted to assess the frequency and nature of metacognitive teaching strategies used by teachers. An observation protocol will be developed to systematically record instances of metacognitive practices, such as prompting students to reflect on their learning, encouraging self-assessment, and using metacognitive prompts. These observations will help identify how often and in what ways metacognitive strategies are integrated into daily instruction (Angelo & Cross, 2012).

Interviews: Semi-structured interviews will be conducted with each teacher to explore their perceptions of student abilities and their use of metacognitive strategies. The interview questions will focus on teachers' beliefs about the effectiveness of these strategies, their experiences with different student populations, and any barriers they face in implementing metacognitive practices. This method allows for in-depth exploration of teachers'

Reflexivity/Ethics

Reflexivity is crucial in qualitative research to acknowledge the researcher's role and potential biases in the study. As a researcher, I will maintain a reflexive journal to document my thoughts, feelings, and reactions throughout the data collection and analysis process. This practice helps to identify and mitigate any biases that may influence the interpretation of the data (Saldana, 2011). Ethical considerations are paramount in this study. All participants will provide informed consent before participating in the study. Confidentiality will be maintained by anonymizing the data, and participants will have the right to withdraw from the study at any time. Ethical approval will be obtained from the relevant institutional review board (IRB) before data collection begins (Saldana, 2011).

Expected Outcomes

This study aims to uncover potential disparities in the use of metacognitive strategies between teachers in different school settings. It is expected that teachers in higher SES schools may employ these strategies more frequently, given the typically higher expectations and resource availability. Conversely, teachers in Title I schools may face challenges that hinder their use of metacognitive practices. The findings will provide insights into how to better support teachers in implementing effective metacognitive strategies across diverse educational contexts (Graham & Perin, 2007).

Results

Coding Methods

The data for this pilot study was analyzed using thematic coding, a method recommended by Saldana (2011) for its effectiveness in qualitative research. Thematic coding involves identifying patterns or themes within qualitative data, which can then be used to describe the data set comprehensively. This approach was chosen because it allows for a detailed understanding of teachers' use of metacognitive strategies and their perceptions of student abilities across different school settings. The coding process involved reading through the observation notes and interview transcripts multiple times to identify recurring themes. These themes were then categorized and analyzed to provide a narrative explanation of the findings.

Engagement and Interactive Strategies

Classroom observations highlighted stark contrasts in student engagement between the instructional practices of Mr. B and Mr. C. Mr. C's use of traditional, passive instructional methods such as direct lectures and presentations led to low levels of student interaction. For instance, during an AP Human Geography lesson, Mr. C's attempt to engage students through discussion resulted in minimal participation, with many students distracted and disinterested. Mr. C noted, "I use a lot of group work and, uh, projects. We also watch videos and use maps. I think these methods work, but... sometimes the students don't seem that interested" (Interview Transcript #1). This lack of engagement was further highlighted during reflective journaling activities, where students' entries were often brief and superficial, indicating a shallow level of cognitive engagement. Mr. C remarked, "Well, during the urbanization unit, I had them keep journals about their thoughts and questions. We discussed these in class. It was okay, but... I think it could have been better" (Interview Transcript #1).

The more dynamic teaching approach by Mr. B fostered a highly engaging classroom environment. His use of interactive activities such as debates, group projects, and simulations encouraged students to participate and apply critical thinking skills actively. A notable example was a simulation of the Congress of Vienna, where students, acting as diplomats, negotiated treaties and alliances. Mr. B explained, "We did a simulation of the Congress of Vienna where students took on roles of different historical figures. They had to negotiate and agree, which helped them understand the complexities of diplomacy and historical context" (Interview Transcript #2). Mr. B's reflective journaling and Socratic seminars further supported critical thinking and self-assessment, as students posed thoughtful questions and engaged in meaningful discussions. "I incorporate reflective journaling and Socratic seminars where students discuss and question each other’s ideas. These activities help students internalize their learning and develop critical thinking skills" (Interview Transcript #2). These observations suggest that interactive and student-centered teaching methods significantly enhance student engagement, in contrast to the more passive techniques observed in Mr. C’s class.

Challenges in Implementing Metacognitive Practices

The implementation of metacognitive strategies also varied significantly between the two schools. Mr. C, who was instructing students in the AP Summer Bootcamp at Polytechnic High School, faced notable challenges in this area. His attempts to integrate reflective journaling into lessons, such as during a unit on urbanization, were met with limited success. Students often produced shallow reflections and required frequent reminders to stay focused, reflecting a lack of familiarity and comfort with metacognitive practices. Mr. C expressed, "I try to have them write in journals and we do some class discussions. But, um, getting them to really think deeply... that's been challenging. I'm not sure I'm doing it right" (Interview Transcript #1). Mr. C attributed some of these challenges to the socio-economic difficulties faced by his students, which he believed affected their ability to engage deeply with the material. "Many of my students have a lot going on outside of school, and it’s hard for them to concentrate fully" (Interview Transcript #1).

Using more effective metacognitive strategies, Mr. B, who was teaching at the AP Bootcamp at Dunbar High School, instructed in a generally more cognitively rigorous manner. His confidence in implementing reflective practices, likely influenced by his experience at a higher SES school, led to richer cognitive engagement among students. During Socratic seminars, students engaged deeply with the material, asking insightful questions and challenging each other's viewpoints. Mr. B detailed, "During our unit on revolutions, I had students keep a journal where they reflected on each revolution’s causes, events, and outcomes. We then used these reflections in a class debate, which helped them articulate and deepen their understanding" (Interview Transcript #2). This approach not only fostered critical thinking but also encouraged students to take ownership of their learning. "I incorporate reflective journaling and Socratic seminars where students discuss and question each other’s ideas. These activities help students internalize their learning and develop their critical thinking skills" (Interview Transcript #2). The disparity in the effectiveness of metacognitive practices highlights the importance of teacher confidence and experience in fostering deeper cognitive engagement among students.

Teacher Perceptions and Biases

Teacher perceptions and biases also played a crucial role in shaping instructional practices. Mr. C expressed uncertainty about his ability to engage students effectively, which may have contributed to the lower levels of student engagement and the superficial implementation of metacognitive practices at Polytechnic High School. Mr. C admitted, "I'm not sure if I'm reaching them the way I should be" (Interview Transcript #1). His perception of the socio-economic challenges faced by his students seemed to influence his teaching approach, potentially limiting his effectiveness. Mr. C noted, "It's tough when you know they're dealing with so much outside of school. It’s hard to get them to focus on metacognition" (Interview Transcript #1).

Mr. B demonstrated a strong belief in the potential of all students, regardless of their background. His culturally responsive teaching methods, which included incorporating diverse perspectives and fostering a collaborative learning environment, reflected his commitment to supporting marginalized students. Mr. B stated, "I include diverse perspectives and examples in my lessons. I also make an effort to learn about my students’ backgrounds and incorporate their experiences into our discussions to make the material more relevant to them" (Interview Transcript #2). This positive perception likely contributed to the higher levels of student engagement and the effective implementation of metacognitive strategies observed in his classroom. "When students see their own experiences reflected in the material, they are more engaged and motivated to learn" (Interview Transcript #2). These findings underscore the significant impact of teacher perceptions and biases on student engagement and the effectiveness of metacognitive practices. Addressing these biases through targeted professional development can help teachers better support diverse student populations.

Discussion

This is where you take your results and discuss what they might mean and/or their implications. Discussions can focus on any or all of the following:

1. why you might have gotten the results you did,
2. what you found that was unexpected or weird,
3. what do you (or others) need to do further research on,

4. how this info might be use to modify practice.

In addition to this, for this pilot you will be asked to include the following subsection in which you discuss how conducting the pilot gave you ideas for how you would modify your study

Modifications to Study Based on Pilot Results

Use this section to describe how the results of the pilot study might inform the design of a real, larger scale study. What you would do differently? How would you modify your interview schedule or observation techniques? Did your research help you better determine what your research questions should be? Should you modify your procedure? How should you sample participants if you do this on a larger scale? Who else should you obtain interviews/observations from?

Length: 3-5 pages, , Times New Roman, 12 point, double spaced.

Class Reflection

This section is the general reflection on the class. Include what you learned, what you struggled with, and how you would like to see the class improved.

Length: 1 page, Times New Roman, 12 point, double spaced.

References

Put your APA citations here in alphabetical order.

Appendix A: Permission to Access Your Population

Attach a copy of the email or written permission you received to access your population.

Appendix B: Pilot Interview Schedule

Include your original interview schedule.

Appendix C: Proposed Revision to Interview Schedule

Include how you would revise the interview schedule based on the results of your interview.

Appendix D: Informed Consent

Attach copies of your informed consent letter showing your participant read and signed off on the interview.

Appendix E: Codebook

Please provide a copy of your codebook with your big themes, subcodes and definitions for each.

Action Research Plan

Name	Melissa Alexander-Blythe
Your Research Question	How does coaching an AP U.S. Government and Politics teacher to use AP Classroom in a collaborative way affect student engagement and metacognitive thinking over a three-week period?
Your role as a researcher	- Coach & Model – demonstrate AP Classroom collaborative lessons - Co-plan weekly lessons with the teacher observe one class per week - Provide feedback and coaching notes.
Scope	Three-week project focused on using AP Classroom progress checks and topic questions collaboratively to improve AP Gov student engagement and metacognition.
Research site and participants	Site: Dunbar High School, Fort Worth ISD. Participants: One AP Gov teacher and the entire AP Gov class (about 25–30 students).
Data collection procedures	1. AP Classroom Progress-Check Scores – Pre-test in Week 1 and post-test at end of Week 3. 2. Engagement Observation Checklist – weekly observation of student collaboration, peer questions, and evidence of students explaining their reasoning. 3. Student Metacognition Exit Tickets – short prompts after each collaborative lesson (e.g., strategies used, group help, changes for next time). 4. Teacher Reflections – weekly 10-minute interview and notes on engagement and metacognition. 5. Researcher Coaching Log – record of planning sessions and feedback.

Dates/Times to collect data	Baseline: 10/07/25 09:00 AM – Pre-test Progress Check During Action Research: 10/09/25 09:00 AM – Observation #1, Exit Ticket #1, Teacher Reflection #1 10/16/25 09:00 AM – Observation #2, Exit Ticket #2, Teacher Reflection #2 10/23/25 09:00 AM – Observation #3, Exit Ticket #3, Teacher Reflection #3 Final: 10/25/25 09:00 AM – Post-test Progress Check
Validity and reliability	Multiple data sources (scores, observations, student reflections, teacher reflections, coaching log) confirm patterns. Member check: share summary findings with the teacher to verify accuracy. Secure, password-protected storage for all data.
Ethical considerations	No IRB required because this is a class project. Obtain principal/site approval. Inform students and parents that reflections are voluntary and anonymous. Use codes instead of names in all notes and reports.
To-do list	~~1. Confirm class-project status with professor – by 9/23/25.~~ ~~2. Obtain principal/site approval – by 9/23/25.~~ 3. Finalize observation checklist and exit-ticket prompts – by 10/03/25. 4. Collect baseline AP Classroom scores – 10/07/25. 5. Model first collaborative lesson – Week of 10/07/25. 6. Conduct weekly observations and coaching – 10/09, 10/16, 10/23. 7. Collect post-test scores – 10/25/25. 8. Analyze data and draft report – by 11/08/25.

Tool 2: Observation Checklist (Engagement & Metacognition)

Format: One-page checklist with space for notes.

☐ Students work together in pairs/groups
☐ Students ask questions of peers
☐ Students explain their reasoning out loud
☐ Teacher prompts students to reflect on strategies
☐ Evidence of engagement (hands raised, on-task talk, etc.)

Notes Section:

Tool 3: Student Exit Ticket (Metacognition)

Purpose: Capture students’ reflections about their learning strategies.

Google Form (3 questions).

1. What strategy helped you most during today’s activity?

____

2. How did working with others change or deepen your understanding?

____

3. What is one thing you would do differently next time?

____

Student ID (Code)	Pre-Test Score (%)	Post-Test Score (%)	Growth (+/-)
1	47	82	**Column 1**
2	45	95	**50**
3	44	78	**34**
4	39	80	**41**
5	42	76	**34**
6	39	88	**49**
7	40	74	**34**
8	41	81	**40**
9	43	79	**36**
10	40	72	**32**
11	37	85	**48**
12	30	77	**47**
13	38	83	**45**
14	37	75	**38**
15	38	75	**37**

Melissa Alexander-Blythe

EDF 725

Dr. Yuan

Conceptual Framework for Investigating Metacognition in AP Classrooms

In qualitative research, a conceptual framework serves as a blueprint that shapes the investigation, helping to clarify the research problem, refine questions, and guide data collection and analysis. This study explores how Advanced Placement (AP) teachers incorporate reflection as a metacognitive tool to foster student growth and improve learning outcomes, particularly in underserved schools. Research has long documented disparities in instructional strategies between well-resourced and Title I schools, yet the role of structured reflection in AP settings remains underexamined. Reflection is a well-established tool for deep learning, encouraging students to assess their understanding, refine strategies, and build independence. However, in the high-pressure environment of AP courses—especially in schools with limited resources—reflection is often sacrificed in favor of content coverage and exam preparation.

This study is grounded in several key theories that underscore the importance of reflection in learning and equitable instruction. Schön's (1983) Reflective Practitioner Theory differentiates between reflection-in-action and reflection-on-action, both of which play a critical role in refining teaching methods and fostering deeper student engagement. Vygotsky's (1978) Social Constructivist Theory highlights the role of social interactions in learning, suggesting that structured reflection helps students internalize knowledge and apply it more effectively. Flavell's (1979) Metacognition Theory further emphasizes the importance of self-awareness in learning, arguing that structured reflection helps students evaluate their comprehension, adjust their strategies, and ultimately enhance their academic performance. More recent studies reaffirm these theories, demonstrating the direct link between metacognitive practices and academic success, particularly in high-stakes learning environments (Tanner, 2012; Zohar & Barzilai, 2013).

Culturally responsive teaching–introduced by Ladson-Billings (1995) and later expanded by Hammond (2015)–stresses the importance of instructional practices that connect with students' backgrounds and experiences. Reflection is a key component of culturally responsive pedagogy, allowing students to draw meaningful connections between their lived experiences and academic content, thereby improving engagement and comprehension. Additionally, Zimmerman's (2002) Self-Regulated Learning Theory posits that reflection is fundamental to self-directed learning, enabling students to set goals, track progress, and adjust their approaches to achieve success. AP students, particularly those in underfunded schools, may benefit immensely from explicit instruction in reflective practices as a means of bridging achievement gaps and fostering academic resilience.

Despite strong evidence supporting the role of reflection in learning, many AP teachers do not consistently incorporate structured reflective practices into their instruction, particularly in Title I schools where standardized testing pressures take priority and barriers to teacher perception of student ability are often present. This study seeks to address the following key questions: How do AP teachers perceive the role of reflection in student learning and achievement? What barriers prevent teachers from implementing reflection practices in underserved schools? How do instructional approaches differ between teachers in varying socioeconomic settings? By exploring these questions, this study aims to contribute to the field of advanced academics by identifying best practices and informing policy recommendations that promote equity in AP education.

Employing a multiple-case study approach, this research will involve semi-structured interviews with AP teachers to explore their perceptions and experiences with reflection, classroom observations to assess how reflection and metacognitive practices are embedded in instruction, and document analysis of lesson plans (as available) and student reflections to identify patterns in reflective practice. A thematic analysis will be conducted to uncover common trends and differences between higher SES and Title I schools.

By investigating how AP teachers use—or neglect—reflection as a tool for student learning, this study aims to highlight practical strategies that make advanced coursework more equitable. The findings will contribute to professional development efforts, equipping educators with strategies to integrate metacognitive techniques that not only support academic success but also foster long-term cognitive growth in students.

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Positionality Reflection: Identity and Pedagogical Outlook

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CI 704

Dr. Huanshu Yuan

April 16, 2024

In education, the interplay of identity and learning strategies deeply influences metacognitive processes (Crenshaw, 1989; hooks, 1994; Freire, 1970). Personal narratives, like my own, forged from a working-class background, rural upbringing, and distinct gender identity, hold a transformative potential that significantly shapes academic interactions. As the first college graduate on both sides of my extended family, born into a very working-class environment, I bring a unique perspective to my pedagogical practice. My upbringing, devoid of access to advanced classes and rooted in a conservative household, has instilled in me both resilience and an acute awareness of educational inequities. These experiences have shaped how I approach my work as an educator, infusing it with empathy and a commitment to advocating for students from similar backgrounds.

Growing up without access to advanced classes made me acutely aware of the disparities in educational opportunities. It drives me to advocate for all students, particularly those from marginalized backgrounds, ensuring they have access to the resources and support they need to succeed. My working-class background has instilled in me a sense of empathy and understanding for students facing similar challenges. It motivates me to create a supportive and inclusive learning environment where all students feel valued and empowered. Additionally, my rural upbringing has fostered in me a deep appreciation for hands-on learning experiences and a connection to nature, which I integrate into my teaching practices to engage students with diverse learning styles.

Being raised in a conservative household and later grappling with the privilege of being white has been a journey of self-reflection and growth. As a teacher working with marginalized students, I've had to confront my own biases and work through my savior complex. Understanding the impact of my privilege has been a humbling experience, driving me to continuously educate myself and strive for equity in my teaching practices. It has taught me the importance of centering the voices and experiences of marginalized communities, amplifying their perspectives in the classroom, and advocating for systemic change within educational institutions. Furthermore, my experiences navigating conservative ideologies have equipped me with the ability to engage in difficult conversations with students and colleagues, fostering a classroom environment where diverse perspectives are respected and valued.

Furthermore, structural challenges within educational systems disproportionately burden marginalized learners, dictating opportunities based on power dynamics and privilege (Crenshaw, 1989; Paris, 2012). Affluent students often access high-quality educational resources, private tutors, and extracurricular activities, enhancing their academic development. Conversely, marginalized students may attend underfunded schools with limited resources, face language barriers, or lack access to stable housing, hindering their educational progress. These disparities not only affect academic achievement but also shape students' self-perception, aspirations, and sense of belonging within educational spaces. Recognizing and urgently addressing these systemic inequities is essential for creating an inclusive learning environment where all students can thrive. As someone who has experienced firsthand the impact of such disparities, I am deeply committed to dismantling these structural barriers and advocating for equitable educational opportunities for all students.

My pedagogical outlook has undergone a profound transformation through the lens of intersectionality and critical pedagogy, reshaping my understanding of how educational systems perpetuate inequality and marginalization. Intersectionality, as conceptualized by Kimberlé Crenshaw (1989), illuminates the interconnectedness of social identities and the complex ways in which power operates within educational contexts. It underscores the importance of recognizing and addressing the intersecting forms of oppression that shape students' experiences, particularly those from marginalized communities. This framework has challenged me to critically examine the ways in which educational practices, including curriculum development and instructional methodologies, may inadvertently reinforce systems of privilege and exclusion. As someone who has navigated intersecting identities, including gender, socioeconomic status, and race, I am committed to creating educational spaces that honor and validate the lived experiences of all students.

Delving deeper into the historical context of education, I've come to realize the role of advanced academic programs in perpetuating inequality. These programs, initially designed as havens for white students to evade integration efforts in public schools, have evolved into bastions of privilege and gateways to elite institutions (Oakes, 1985). The criteria for admission often reflect cultural biases and favor students from affluent backgrounds, further entrenching disparities along racial, socioeconomic, and gender lines (Oakes, 1985; Ladson-Billings, 2006). As an educator committed to equity and social justice, this realization has prompted me to critically interrogate the structures and practices within advanced academic programs and advocate for reforms that promote access and inclusivity for all students. Drawing from my own experiences of navigating educational barriers, I am dedicated to challenging these inequities and advocating for policies that ensure equitable access to educational opportunities for all students, regardless of their background or identity.

Critical pedagogy, inspired by the works of Paulo Freire (1970) and bell hooks (1994), has been instrumental in guiding my pedagogical praxis. Freire's notion of conscientização, or critical consciousness, highlights the transformative potential of education in fostering critical awareness and social action. By encouraging students to critically analyze and challenge oppressive structures, critical pedagogy empowers them to become agents of change in their communities. Similarly, hooks' emphasis on education as a practice of freedom underscores the liberatory potential of education in challenging hegemonic narratives and fostering inclusive learning environments. These insights have deepened my commitment to creating educational spaces that prioritize equity, justice, and liberation for all students. As an educator who has grappled with the complexities of privilege and power dynamics, I am committed to facilitating critical dialogue and empowering students to critically engage with the world around them.

Culturally sustaining pedagogy, as articulated by Django Paris (2012), offers a framework for designing educational experiences that honor and affirm diverse cultural backgrounds and experiences. This approach challenges the notion of a singular, dominant culture in education and advocates for the integration of culturally relevant content and teaching practices into the curriculum. By centering the voices and experiences of marginalized communities, culturally sustaining pedagogy promotes a sense of belonging and empowerment among students. As an educator, I strive to incorporate culturally sustaining pedagogy principles into my practice, ensuring all students feel valued, represented, and engaged in their learning journey. This commitment extends beyond simply integrating diverse content; it involves actively engaging with students' cultural backgrounds, languages, and experiences to create a learning environment that fosters their identity development and success.

In my journey as an educator, these insights have fueled my commitment to reimagining curriculum development and instructional practices through an intersectional and culturally sustaining lens. I recognize the importance of critically evaluating existing educational structures, challenging biases, and amplifying marginalized voices in the educational discourse. By embracing intersectionality, critical pedagogy, and culturally sustaining pedagogy, educators can work towards creating transformative educational experiences that empower students to engage with the world and enact positive change critically.

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Annotated Bibliographies 1, 2, and 3

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Annotated Bibliography 1

9 October 2023

Edwards, L., Hughes, K. L., & Weisberg, A. (2019). Different approaches to dual enrollment: Understanding program features and their implications. *Community College Review*, 47(2), 144-167.

This work dives deep into the diverse modalities of dual enrollment programs, highlighting how these structures influence pedagogical practices. The authors peel back the layers of dual enrollment, revealing that these programs are not one-size-fits-all but vary significantly. Their investigation is a reminder that without adept instructional practices, even the most well-intentioned programs can flounder. As dual enrollment becomes an increasingly pivotal bridge between high school and college, this research provides critical insights into how instructional quality can make or break this transition. It's a must-read for those keen on understanding the intertwining of curriculum theory and pedagogical prowess.

Dixson, Dante D. "A Call to Reframe Gifted Education as Maximizing Learning." *Phi Delta Kappan*, vol. 102, no. 4, 2020, pp. 22-25.

Dante D. Dixson advocates for a reimagining of gifted education, urging stakeholders to transition from traditional, restrictive perceptions of 'giftedness' to a broader vision of maximizing learning potential for all students. Dixson discusses the inherent limitations of conventional gifted education programs and presents an argument for inclusive practices that grow and support the abilities and talents of every student, regardless of conventional labels. Dixson's perspective is both refreshing and challenging. By questioning the antiquated constructs of gifted education, he pushes educators and policymakers to re-evaluate their beliefs and practices. While the premise is progressive and promising, its successful implementation demands rigorous curriculum redesigns and pedagogical practices. The idea of 'maximizing learning' is admirable, but its realization would require considerable systemic shifts and an abundance of resources. For researchers and educators invested in redefining the boundaries of gifted education and promoting equity in learning opportunities, this article serves as a catalyst. It underscores the pressing need to dismantle archaic paradigms in gifted education and align with a more inclusive, growth-oriented approach. Dixson's charge is especially pertinent in today's diverse classrooms, where the primary goal should be to harness and nurture the potential in every student, moving beyond traditional labels and stereotypes.

Annotated Bibliography 2

20 October 2023

Kyburg, Robin M., Holly Hertberg-Davis, and Carolyn M. Callahan. "Advanced Placement and International Baccalaureate Programs: Optimal Learning Environments for Talented Minorities?" *Journal of Advanced Academics*, vol. 18, no. 2, Winter.

In their comprehensive study, Kyburg, Hertberg-Davis, and Callahan examine the effectiveness of Advanced Placement (AP) and International Baccalaureate (IB) programs in catering to the educational needs of talented minority students. The authors delve deep into the implications these programs have on minority students and assess whether these avenues indeed provide an optimized environment conducive to their academic growth. Through their research, the authors illuminate the intricate balance between standardized educational programs and the unique needs of diverse student populations. Their findings provide insight into the potential disparities in the effectiveness of these programs. For educators, policymakers, and researchers who are looking into the impact of such advanced curricular programs on minority students, this article offers a nuanced perspective. The study underscores the need for a continuous reassessment of these programs to ensure inclusivity and equity in meeting the needs of a diverse student population, urging stakeholders to recognize and address any existing shortcomings.

Dial, M. F. "The Impact of Classroom Instructional Practices in Math on Achievement or Underachievement for Academically Gifted and Talented Students." Walden University, ProQuest Dissertations Publishing, 2011. 3461793.

Dial's doctoral dissertation presents an in-depth exploration of how specific classroom instructional practices in mathematics affect the academic outcomes of gifted and talented students. This research seeks to discern the pedagogical nuances that can either enhance or hinder the mathematical prowess of students who display advanced academic capabilities. The crux of Dial's findings revolves around the notion that even within the realm of gifted education, there isn't a one-size-fits-all instructional approach. The study clarifies that the success of math instruction for this demographic hinges on a multifaceted interplay of curriculum depth, instructional quality, and individual student needs. For educators and curriculum developers aiming to harness the full potential of gifted and talented students in mathematics, this research serves as a guide. It accentuates the imperative of tailored instruction, which not only challenges these students but also aligns with their unique learning trajectories, paving the way for optimal academic outcomes.

Annotated Bibliography 3

20 October 2023

Snyder, Scott. "A Phenomenological Study of How High School Advanced Placement Classes Prepared First-Generation College Students for Postsecondary Education." Lamar University - Beaumont, ProQuest Dissertations Publishing, 2013. 3562346.

The research dives deep into the experiences of first-generation college students and their perceptions of how high school Advanced Placement (AP) classes influenced their readiness for postsecondary education. By focusing on this particular demographic, Snyder highlights the unique challenges and expectations faced by first-generation college attendees. The findings shed light on the multifaceted impact of AP classes, ranging from content mastery to developing critical study habits and academic self-efficacy. Through a series of personal narratives and insights, the study paints a vivid picture of the transformative power of a rigorous high school curriculum while also highlighting potential gaps and areas of improvement. For educators, administrators, and policymakers keen on enhancing the transition from high school to college for first-generation students, Snyder's research offers invaluable perspectives. It emphasizes the need for intentional support structures and the continuous evolution of AP courses to meet the distinctive needs of these students, ensuring their successful navigation through the higher education landscape.

Saffore, Pamela. "The Relationship Between AP Course Enrollment, Dual-Credit Course Enrollment, High School GPA and Post-Secondary Outcomes in Black Girls." Southern Illinois University at Edwardsville, ProQuest Dissertations Publishing, 2023. 30567753.

Saffore's research offers a detailed exploration into the intertwined relationships between AP course enrollment, dual-credit course enrollment, high school GPA, and the subsequent post-secondary outcomes, specifically in Black girls. This pivotal study brings to the forefront the academic trajectories and experiences of a demographic that has historically been underrepresented in educational research. By dissecting the impact and interplay of these academic variables, Saffore highlights the potential advantages and pitfalls Black girls encounter as they navigate the educational system. The findings emphasize the significance of rigorous high school courses, like AP and dual credit, in shaping college readiness and future academic success. However, they also underscore the necessity of holistic support systems that account for the unique challenges faced by Black girls. For educators, counselors, and policymakers striving to amplify equity in educational outcomes, this dissertation is a treasure trove of insights. It champions the imperative of tailored academic pathways and robust support structures to ensure that Black girls not only access rigorous courses but also thrive in and beyond their post-secondary endeavors.

The Impact of Technology on Student Learning and Metacognition

A paper submitted to

CIEC 700 at

Marshall University

in partial fulfillment of

the requirements for the degree of

Doctor of Education

in

Curriculum & Instruction

by

Melissa Alexander-Blythe

November 6, 2023

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The impact of technology on student learning, particularly in the domain of metacognition, is a topic of increasing interest and importance. This paper seeks to explore how technology impacts student metacognition and why it is crucial to study this impact. Metacognition has emerged as a crucial component of student success, and the use of technology in the classroom has the potential to enhance learning outcomes. However, its impact on metacognitive development is not yet well understood. This paper explores the current research on the impact of technology on student metacognition, seeking to unravel the extent and manner in which various technology platforms impact student metacognitive skills. The reviewed literature highlights the importance of smart learning environments, clicker technology, learning logs, and flipped learning environments in fostering metacognitive skill development. The investigation underscores the reciprocal nature of self-regulation and technology, suggesting that technology can act as a metacognitive scaffold to promote student success. As we continue to infuse technology into classrooms, it is essential to examine its impact on student learning, particularly in the development of metacognitive skills. Through exploring the impact of technology on metacognitive development, we can harness technology to its full potential, advancing our understanding of how metacognition can be cultivated in the classroom and promoting equity in learning outcomes.

The impact of technology on student learning, particularly in the domain of metacognition, is a topic of increasing interest and importance. As technology continues to evolve and find its way into classrooms, it is essential to examine how its use impacts student metacognition. This paper seeks to explore the questions that surround how technology impacts student learning and why it is crucial to study this impact. Metacognition has emerged as a crucial component of student success, with studies finding that students who possess strong metacognitive skills are better equipped to manage their own learning, set goals, and adapt to new challenges. The use of technology in the classroom has the potential to enhance learning outcomes, but its impact on metacognitive development is not yet well understood. As such, it is essential to explore how technology can be leveraged to support metacognitive development and advance our understanding of how this critical skill can be cultivated in the classroom. This paper explores the current research on the impact of technology on student metacognition, seeking to unravel the extent and manner in which various technology platforms impact student metacognitive skills. By examining the literature, we hope to shed light on the potential of technology to enhance metacognitive development and identify the best practices for integrating technology into the classroom to support this goal. As we continue to infuse technology into classrooms at a swift pace, it is essential to examine its impact on student learning. By exploring the impact of technology on metacognitive development, we can ensure that technology is harnessed to its full potential, promoting student success and advancing our understanding of how metacognition can be cultivated in the classroom. The importance of this inquiry cannot be overstated, as it has significant implications for the future of education and the role of technology in fostering students' ability to monitor and regulate their own learning.

The literature on the influence of technology on student metacognition is vast and varied, reflecting the growing interest in this field. The research reviewed in this paper meticulously examines a corpus of studies to unravel the extent and manner in which various technology platforms impact student metacognitive skills. One of the noteworthy findings of the reviewed research is the rise of smart learning environments tailored to enhancing metacognitive abilities among students. Ardini, Suwandi, Senowarsito, and Adebisi's (2022) research underpins the construction of these environments, embedded with features enabling students to consciously reflect upon and manage their learning trajectories. The deployment of strategic prompts, reflection pauses, and self-assessment tools within the smart learning platform illustrates how technology can act as a metacognitive scaffold. This in-depth exploration sheds light on the technology's role in nurturing an acute awareness among students regarding their cognitive strategies and knowledge comprehension.

Another notable study by Bunce et al. (2022) provides empirical evidence on the efficacy of clicker technology complemented with confidence level questioning in a general chemistry course. Their study isolates the dynamics of metacognitive development by analyzing students' ability to judge their understanding and misconceptions during live polling. The researchers discovered that such technology-facilitated interventions are especially beneficial in aiding lower-achieving students to bridge gaps in their understanding, thus promoting equity in learning outcomes. Moreover, the study extends its scope by correlating metacognitive gains with improved academic performance, thereby underpinning the consequential role of feedback in self-regulated learning. Learning logs offer another reflective practice tool that prompts students to articulate their learning experiences.

Branigan and Donaldson's (2019) longitudinal analysis presents learning logs as a reflective practice tool that matures students' metacognitive insights and fosters a culture of self-assessment and adaptive learning strategies. Shyr and Chen (2017) pivot the discourse towards flipped learning environments, examining how such frameworks can promote metacognitive competency through self-regulated learning. The study scrutinizes a flipped learning system where students prepare for class by engaging with digital content at their own pace. Findings indicate that this pre-class engagement primes students for higher-order thinking in the subsequent face-to-face sessions, enhancing their ability to regulate their learning and adjust strategies in real time based on comprehension levels. This investigation underscores the reciprocal nature of self-regulation and technology, suggesting that flipped learning environments can be a breeding ground for metacognitive skill development.

Woodward and Cho's (2020) research delves into the role of beliefs about knowledge in the context of online multiple-source reading. Through qualitative analysis, the study echoes the importance of epistemic cognition, which is closely allied to metacognitive processes. It highlights how students navigate, evaluate, and integrate information from disparate online sources and how their metacognitive awareness is imperative for such tasks. The implications for classroom instruction are significant, as the authors advocate for pedagogies that amplify critical thinking and metacognitive awareness, especially in an era increasingly dominated by digital information flux. Finally, the contrast between in-person and online learning environments provided by Maor et al. (2023) offers a contemporary look at how emergency remote teaching during the COVID-19 pandemic has impacted creative thinking and metacognition. Their comparative study reveals that although Zoom-based learning challenged traditional metacognitive strategies due to its novel format, it also engendered new approaches to thinking about thinking. The research provides a nuanced perspective on the variations in student metacognition in different settings, emphasizing the adaptability of metacognitive strategies to various instructional mediums.

Overall, the literature presents a compelling narrative that educational technology, when mindfully implemented, holds the promise of substantially advancing student metacognitive abilities. Nonetheless, the research concurrently signals that the success of such technological interventions is contingent upon their deliberate alignment with pedagogical objectives that prioritize and understand the nature of metacognition.

Although the studies reviewed suggest that using technology in the classroom can positively impact students' metacognitive development, there are still gaps in the collective understanding of how to implement technology to achieve this goal most effectively, as well as the potential downsides of relying too heavily on technology. For example, while some studies highlight the benefits of smart learning platforms and online resources, others caution that students need guidance in developing the critical thinking skills necessary to evaluate and contextualize the information they encounter. Further research is needed to understand better how to design and implement technology in ways that support metacognitive growth while also addressing potential challenges or drawbacks. Additionally, it will be important to explore how the role of the instructor may need to adapt in response to the increasing integration of technology in educational settings.

The potential implications of technology on student learning are vast and varied. With the integration of advanced technologies like Artificial Intelligence (AI), Virtual Reality (VR), and Augmented Reality (AR), education is poised to undergo a significant transformation in the coming years. These technologies can create immersive learning experiences that can help students develop critical thinking and problem-solving skills, enhance creativity and collaboration, and provide personalized learning opportunities.

AI-powered educational tools can provide real-time feedback and adaptive learning experiences, helping students identify their strengths and weaknesses and adjust their learning strategies accordingly. VR and AR can create realistic simulations that allow students to explore complex concepts, historical events, and scientific phenomena in a more engaging and interactive way. These technologies can also help bridge the gap between theory and practice, offering students hands-on learning experiences that can prepare them for real-world challenges.

Technology can also provide students access to a vast repository of knowledge and resources that can supplement traditional classroom instruction. Students can leverage digital platforms to access multimedia resources like videos, podcasts, and interactive tutorials that can enhance their understanding of complex concepts. The potential implications of technology on student learning are immense. As we continue to explore the impact of technology on student metacognition, it is critical to keep an open mind and embrace the possibilities these technologies offer. By leveraging technology to its full potential, we can create a learning environment that fosters creativity, collaboration, critical thinking, and problem-solving–preparing students for the challenges they will face as they continue into our technologically saturated world.

As technology continues to evolve and find its way into classrooms, it is essential to examine how its use can support student learning and metacognition. One way that schools can better integrate technology is by leveraging AI to provide personalized learning experiences for each student. AI-powered learning platforms can adapt to each student's needs, providing content and activities that are tailored to their learning style and pace. This not only enhances student engagement but also supports metacognitive development as students become more aware of their own learning processes.

To ensure that the integration of technology in the classroom is successful, there are several factors to consider. Teachers must be intentional and strategic in their use of technology, making sure it is used as a tool to achieve specific learning objectives and meet the individual needs of students. Additionally, it is essential to be mindful of the potential limitations of technology and how it can complement, rather than replace, traditional teaching methods.

To remove the taboo of certain technologies, schools should provide opportunities for students to learn about them and use them in the classroom. For instance, AI-powered tools such as chatbots or virtual assistants can help students with homework or provide feedback on their assignments. By introducing these technologies in the classroom, students can learn how to use them to enhance their learning and become more comfortable using them.

Extensive teacher training and support are critical for the successful integration of technology in the classroom. Teachers need to be familiar with the technology they are using and understand how to use it effectively to support student learning and metacognition. Additionally, teachers need to be trained in how to assess the impact of technology on student learning and adjust their teaching practices accordingly. This training should be ongoing to ensure teachers are up-to-date with the latest technologies and best practices.

Moreover, when it comes to leveraging AI-powered tools, it is essential to consider the ethical implications of their use. Teachers must ensure that the algorithms are transparent, fair, and unbiased. They must also ensure that student privacy is protected and their data is not misused. It is essential to educate students about these ethical considerations and involve them in decision-making processes regarding the use of AI in the classroom. Without doing so, students will be at a disadvantage and potentially create harm for themselves and others.

A solid and usable infrastructure is also critical to successfully integrating technology in the classroom. Teachers should not have to shoot from the hip and create miracles with technology constantly. They should be able to rely on a reliable and up-to-date infrastructure that supports their teaching practices. This includes ensuring that there is adequate bandwidth for various technologies and that there are no technical issues that hinder their use. Teachers can only do so much, and without enough laptops, wifi that functions, and reliable ways to provide students with information, technology can become a hindrance rather than a help. It is this scenario that must be prevented.

Finally, integrating technology into the classroom can potentially enhance student learning and metacognition. However, teachers must be intentional and plan how they will use technology to support specific learning objectives and student needs. Schools should also remove the taboo from certain technologies and provide extensive training and support for teachers and other stakeholders. Additionally, teachers must consider the ethical implications of using AI-powered tools and ensure that students' privacy is protected. Finally, a solid and usable infrastructure is essential for successful integration. By taking these steps, schools can ensure that technology is harnessed to its full potential, promoting student success and advancing our understanding of how metacognition can be cultivated in the classroom.

Collaborative AP Classroom Use to Boost Engagement and Metacognition

AP U.S. Government — Dunbar High School (FWISD)

Melissa Alexander-Blythe

Problem Statement, Context, and Research Question

Students showed uneven engagement and limited reflection on how they learned.

Teacher use of AP Classroom was mostly individual practice, not collaborative learning.

Purpose: Coach and model collaborative AP Classroom routines to increase engagement and metacognitive reflection.

Research Question

- How does coaching an AP U.S. Government teacher to use AP Classroom collaboratively affect student engagement and metacognitive thinking over three weeks?

Context & Participants

Site: Dunbar High School (FWISD)

Participants: 1 AP Gov teacher; 1 section (~15 students)

Timeline: 3 weeks

Action & Methods

- Modeled one collaborative AP Classroom lesson; co-planned weekly lessons.
- Observed one class per week with an engagement/metacognition checklist.
- Collected AP Classroom progress-check scores (pre/post).
- Collected student exit tickets (metacognition reflections).

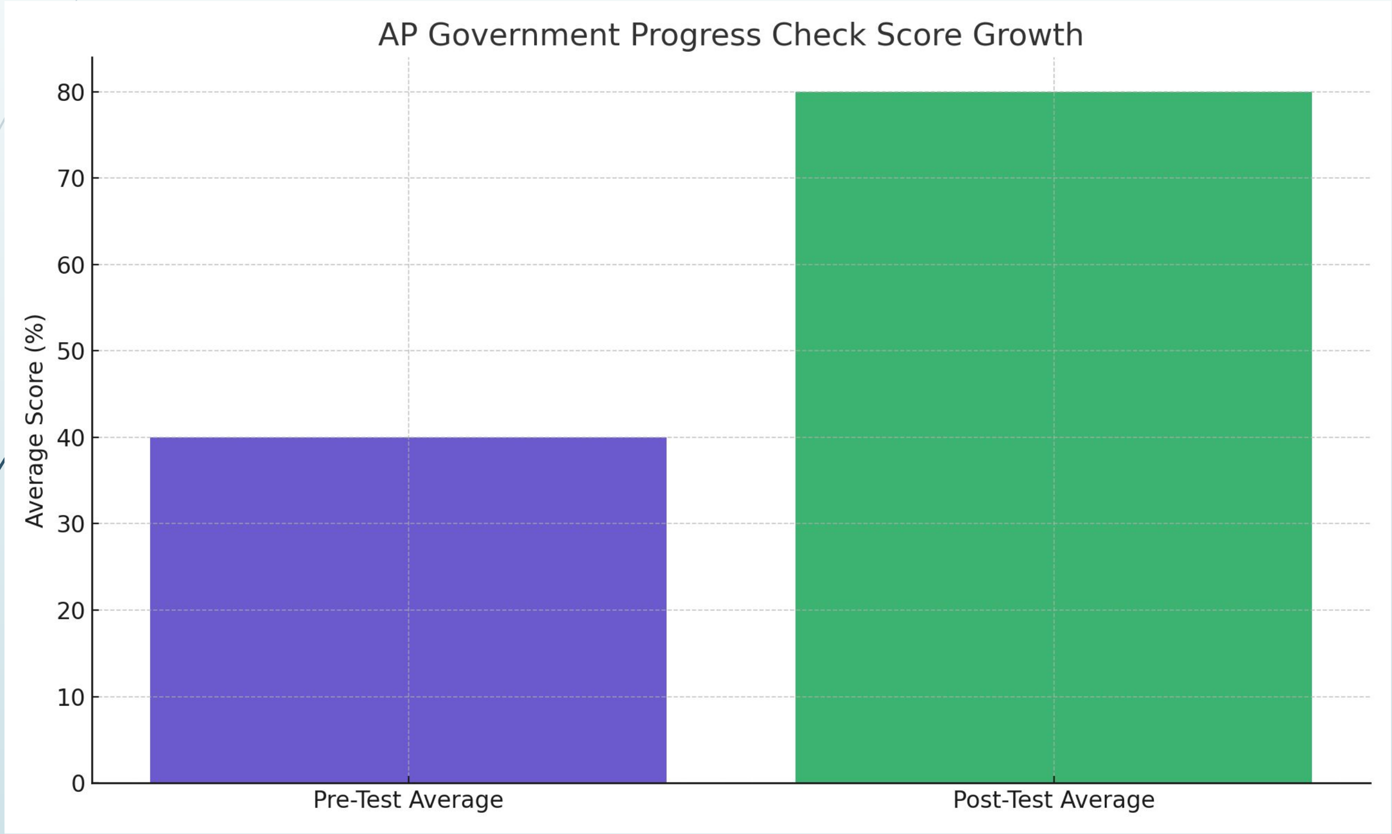
Data Collection Tools

Assessment: AP Classroom progress checks (pre/post).

Observation: Engagement + metacognition checklist with notes.

Survey: 3-question exit ticket on strategy use, impact of collaboration, next step.

Findings: Assessment Growth



Findings: Metacognitive Growth

Students began correcting their own misunderstandings during group work.

Students identified and intentionally used different strategies over time.

Exit ticket responses shifted from short/unspecific to strategy-based explanations.

Teacher Reflection

- Watching the modeled routines changed daily interactions with students.
- Teacher increased use of prompts like “How do you know?” and “Explain your choice.”
- Reported greater student talk and more purposeful collaboration.

Interpretation

- Collaborative AP Classroom routines supported engagement and metacognitive talk.
- Coaching with live modeling influenced teacher practice more than discussion alone.
- Findings align with research on modeling/coaching and metacognitive prompting.

Limitations & Next Steps

LIMITATIONS:

Short timeline and single class limit generalizability.

NEXT STEPS:

Scale to additional sections, build common exit tickets, add inter-rater checks for observations.

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Preparing Educators for AI-Infused Classrooms

Follow along here: https://bit.ly/SITEAIINFUSED

SITE 2026

Agenda

01 Who’s Who in the Room

02 System-Level Gaps in AI Preparation

03 Policy and Equity

04 Classroom Realities and Instructional Coaching

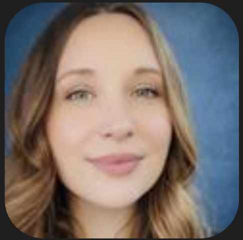
05 AI, Accessibility, and Special Education

06 Technical Fluency, STEM/CTE, and Cross-Disciplinary Literacy

07 Discussion

Meet the panel

Melissa Blythe-Alexander
Fort Worth ISD, TX



Tiffany Clemins
Morgan County Schools, WV

Becky Osterfeld
Beavercreek City Schools, OH

Steve Geddis
Brockton Public Schools, MA

Linda Rich
We Lead CS, KY

MARSHALL

Who's Who in the Room?

Please join our Mentimeter at this time to tell us a little bit more about who you are before we begin.

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Now please share with us some of the words and phrases that come to mind when you think about Generative Artificial Intelligence (Gen AI) in education.

System-Level Gaps in AI Preparation

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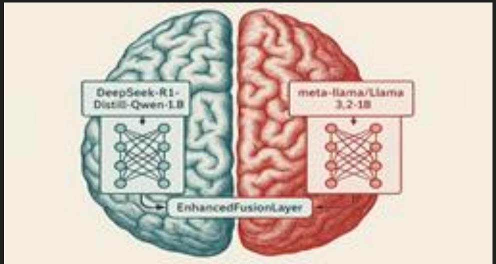
- Growing disconnect between AI-rich classrooms and preservice preparation
- AI is reshaping writing, assessment, and academic integrity
- Increased demand for metacognition and cognitive engagement
- AI must be positioned as a thinking scaffold
- Risk of widening gaps without intentional, equity-centered design
- Preservice teachers need experience with:
    - Instructional design using AI
    - Feedback and revision with AI
    - Equity and access considerations
    - Comparative reasoning and critical thinking tasks
- Teacher prep programs must embed AI into authentic pedagogical practice



Policy and Equity

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- Policy factors:
  - Infrastructure shapes opportunity.
  - Teacher readiness matters.
  - Support must be sustained.
  - Local context should guide AI use.

Classroom Realities & Instructional Coaching

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- Never enough time
- Need for educator Gen AI literacy is great
- Malcolm Knowles and andragogy
  - Involved learners
  - Problem-centered learning
  - Realistic learner experiences
  - Relevance to learners’ educational lives

AI, Accessibility, and Special Education

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- AI is already in classrooms, but many teachers—especially in special education—are not fully trained or supported in using it effectives
- Special educators face heavy workloads (IEPs, data tracking, differentiation), and AI can help streamline these tasks
- Start educating/training pre-service teachers in AI to make them more efficient with the paperwork tasks to free up time for what matters most: **individualized instruction, relationships, and student self-advocacy**
- AI can support differentiation, accessibility, and progress monitoring, making learning more equitable for students with disabilities
- However, AI cannot replace teacher expertise and must always align with **IEP goals, ethical use, and student needs**
- To be effective, AI use requires **ongoing training, equitable access, and intentional integration into real classroom practice**

Technical Fluency, STEM/CTE, and Cross-Disciplinary Literacy

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- Generative AI cannot be ignored in future workforce preparation
- Educators can teach ethical AI use while integrating technical tools
- AI supports learning, scaffolding, and accessibility (e.g., ELL support)
- AI literacy is important across CTE fields, not just computer science
- Goal: future-ready classrooms that foster innovation and critical thinking

You are welcome to continue submitting questions as we talk!

Discussion

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Teacher Use of Metacognitive Practices in AP Classrooms

Melissa Alexander-Blythe
Marshall University
and
Ron Childress,
Marshall University

National Social Science Association
Fall Conference
Hot Springs, AR
Virtual Presentation
October 19-21, 2025

Presentation Goal

Develop an initial foundation for a larger study of teacher practices in the use of metacognitive strategies and learning in advanced curricula in secondary schools.

Metacognition: What is It?

Knowledge about one's own cognitive processes and the ability to monitor and control these processes. (Flavell, 1976).

- *Metacognitive Knowledge* is awareness and regulation of one's cognitive processes.
  - What strategies work best for different tasks and when to use them
  - One's own thinking limitations as a learner
- *Metacognitive Regulation* encompasses planning, monitoring, and evaluating learning.
  - Planning how to approach tasks
  - Monitoring comprehension progress
  - Evaluation the effectiveness of strategies

Flavell (1976); Steiner (2023)

History of Metacognition

- Introduced by John Flavell in the 1970s.
  - The concept of thinking about thinking can be traced back to ancient philosophers like Aristotle and St. Augustine. John Locke also discussed children reflecting on their own thinking. Interest in metacognition grew significantly in the late 20th century through the work of researchers like Ann Brown, who made the distinction between knowledge of cognition and regulation of cognition.
- Rooted in constructivist theory (Piaget, Vygotsky).
- Connected to Dewey’s emphasis on reflective learning.

(Flavell, 1976; Dewey, 1910; Vygotsky

Metacognitive Learning Skills (MLS)

Metacognitive learning skills are application of metacognition-behaviors appropriate for and relevant to improving performance on a specific learning task.

- Self-regulatory strategies: Use metacognitive insights to guide learning (self-assess, monitor, select appropriate task-specific strategies)
- Task Oriented Techniques: Ways learners interact with content to help them remember, learn, think, and understand; may be content or context specific; can be taught as methods

Flavell (1976); Dewey (1910); Vygotsky (1978)

Benefits of Metacognitive Learning

- Knowledge of Cognition: Refers to what learners know about their own thinking, including:
  - Declarative knowledge - awareness of personal learning strengths, weaknesses, and preferences.
  - Procedural knowledge - understanding which strategies are effective for different tasks.
  - Conditional knowledge - knowing when and why to use specific strategies.
- Regulation of Cognition: Involves the active management of one's learning processes. Key components include:
  - Planning - setting goals, selecting strategies, and allocating resources before learning begins.
  - Monitoring - tracking comprehension and task performance during learning.
  - Evaluating - reflecting on outcomes and strategy effectiveness after learning.

Hacker, Dunlosky, & Graesser (2009)

Metacognition and Advanced Secondary Curriculum

- Advanced courses demand deeper thinking
  - Students must engage in analysis, synthesis, and evaluation and not just memorization
- Metacognitive skills are often assumed
  - Many students enter AP and honors courses without explicit instruction in how to manage their own learning
- Instruction should make thinking visible
  - Teachers can support metacognitive growth by modeling strategies, thinking aloud, and prompting student reflection

Conley (2014); McGuire (2021)

Process for Developing Metacognitive Skills

- Embed planning, monitoring, and evaluation in lessons.
- Use scaffolds like reflection prompts and checklists.

Metacognitive Process	**Example in Practice**
Plan	Student sets learning goals; teacher models task analysis
Monitor	Student checks understanding; teacher gives formative feedback
Evaluate	Student reflects; teacher guides self-assessment
Adjust	Student revises strategy; teacher scaffolds reflection

Steiner (2023); National Research Council (2000)

Student Barriers to Metacognition

- Pausing to self-assess is not typical behavior
- Time commitment required to pause and reflect
- Lack of awareness of effective MC strategies
- Avoidance of alternate strategies b/c time required
- A focus on finishing rather than learning
- Distance between short- and long-term goals

(Steiner, nd)

Metacognitive Learning Strategies

- Reflection journals, self-questioning, and learning logs.
- Prediction and confidence-rating exercises.
- Concept mapping and annotation.
- Peer teaching and collaborative metacognition.

(Malamed, 2021; Steiner, 2023)

Metacognitive Teaching Strategies

- Model cognitive processes aloud.
- Use reflective questioning to prompt reasoning.
- Scaffold self-assessment with rubrics and exemplars.
- Embed revision and feedback cycles.

(EEF, 2019; Steiner, 2023)

Monitoring/Assessing Student Metacognitive Learning

- Annotate course text with commentary/questions
- Assign "minute" or "muddiest point" papers
- Use guided reading questions as supplements
- Have students generate potential test questions
- Teach students how to make study guides
- Use student "confidence judgements" on tests
- Compare received and predicted grades
- Student performance analysis of assignments
- Students formally respond to teacher feedback

(Steiner, nd)

Implications for Teacher Prep & PD

- Embed metacognitive pedagogy in teacher education programs.
- Provide reflective PD structures mirroring metacognitive processes.
- Encourage iterative reflection and adjustment.

(Steiner, 2023; Conley, 2014)

Metacognition and Policy Implications

- Incorporate MC skills/strategies into state standards
- Adopt definition CCR that includes MC skills
- Develop assessments that gauge MC skills/behaviors
- Focus on learning process as well as outcomes
- Focus on student development of MC skills/strategies
- Encourage innovation and experimentation
- Expand/intensify research about MC learning/skills
- Integrate MC assessments at the state/local levels
- Encourage P-12 & IHE collaboration
- Integrate MC learning into educator prep and PD

(Conley, 2014)

Continuing Challenges

- Limited teacher training in metacognitive instruction.
- Need for research in diverse, advanced academic contexts.
- AI-supported reflection and feedback tools as emerging area.

(Steiner, 2023; McGuire, 2021)

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NSSA Scholars Fall Conference 2025
Hot Springs, Arkansas
October 19-21

National Social Science Association Board 2025 – 2026

Meet Our NSSA Board Members

NSSA Scholars Fall 2025 Conference Program
Hot Springs, Arkansas
October 19-21

Education Examined

SUNDAY, October 19th, 2025

1:00 pm-5:00 pm	**Registration**	**Atrium**
5:00 pm-7:00 pm	**Reception and Board Members Meeting**	**Atrium**

MONDAY, October 20th, 2025

7:00 am-11:00 am	**Registration**	
7:00 am-9:00 am	**Breakfast**	**Atrium**
9:00 am-11:30 am	**Sessions**	**Salons A & B**
11:45 am-1:00 pm	**Luncheon**	**Atrium**
1:10 pm-5:00 pm	**Sessions**	**Salons A & B**

TUESDAY, October 21, 2025

7:00 am-9:00 am	Breakfast	**Atrium**
9:00 am-11:00 am		**Virtual Presentations**

Zoom Links

https://us06web.zoom.us/j/76698378686 **Salon A**

https://apsu.zoom.us/j/91440399362 **Salon B**

NSSA Paper Presentations Session Meeting Rooms on Monday, October 20

Session Chairs Monday, October 20, 2025

Salon A - Praphul Joshi
Salon B - Benita Bruster

9:00 AM-10:0AM
BREAKOUT
SESSION I
Salon A
Research Papers

Dialogues with the Machine: Introducing Philosophy Students to the Discipline through Socratic Exchanges with Artificial Intelligence

Trevor Hoag
Emporia State University

This presentation will focus on pedagogical experiments I conducted in my Introduction to Philosophy course and plan to continue in upcoming semesters. In the first "sessions," learners prompted ChatGPT to imitate Socrates. Then they conversed with "him," asking the pug-nosed gadfly questions based upon the textual materials from class, like the Republic and the Crito. After asking and answering questions alongside Socrates, learners reflected upon multiple questions: Is the artificial intelligence app. actually "thinking"?

The Evolving Culture of U.S. Higher Education in the Era of Online Learning

Keith Head
Capella University

The culture of higher education in the United States has been significantly transformed by the rapid growth of online learning, accelerated by the COVID-19 pandemic. This research examines how shifting from traditional in-person instruction to online modalities has impacted instructor-student engagement, conversational and community interaction, perceived educational quality, and student responsibility for self-directed learning at both undergraduate and graduate levels.

9:00 AM-10:00 AM

BREAKOUT SESSION

SESSION I

Salon B

Research Papers

Quantifying the Visibility of Twice Exceptional Education

Debbie Troxclair
Lamar University

Twice-exceptional (2e) students—those who are both gifted and have disabilities—remain largely invisible in educational research and practice due to disciplinary silos and inconsistent terminology. This study employs a quantitative content analysis research design to examine the diffusion of the term “twice-exceptional” across 100 peer-reviewed sources from 2010 to 2022 in gifted education, special education, and educational psychology. Findings reveal that while the term is well-established within gifted education, it is rarely referenced in special education or general education literature. This presentation explores the methodological approach, key findings, and actionable recommendations for expanding 2e discourse across educational domains. Attendees will gain insight into how research visibility—or lack thereof—shapes identification, support, and equity for twice-exceptional students.

Did the Gun Really Pull the Trigger: A P-Curve Analysis of the Original Weapons Effect Hypothesis

James Benjamin
University of Arkansas-Fort Smith

Berkowitz and LePage (1967) found an interaction between provocation level and short-term exposure to weapons on aggressive behavior. In subsequent years, efforts to replicate the effect were attempted with varying degrees of success. This p-curve analysis examines whether this particular body of research holds the evidentiary value claimed by other social psychologists (e.g., Carlson et al., 1990). The findings of this p-curve analysis suggest that the evidentiary value of those early experiments may be less than it appears.

10:00 AM-10:25 AM Morning BREAK

10:30 AM-11:30 AM
BREAKOUT

SESSION II Salon A
Research Papers

Words Matter: Confusion in the Math and Science Classroom

Barba Aldis Patton & Teresa LeSage Clements
TAMU-Victoria

As one of my young students asked very politely one day, it made me realize that many words have one meaning, one for context, and one will have a totally different meaning in another setting. No wonder it is confusing. Students are often told to look for the biggest... but is it the size of a figure? Greatest amount? Or even the greatest value? Let's look at examples and why learning the correct academic language is absolutely imperative for young students to become masters in their academics.

Rocket Your Instruction with Math Concepts & Vocabulary

Teresa LeSage Clements & Barba Patton
TAMU-Victoria

National student measures of education progress have consistently shown decreasing test scores, especially in math, reading, and science. Additionally, there are significant differences in math and science achievement between males and females. Clearly, the instruction needs improvement. What is missing in the curriculum? Obviously, if students cannot read, then how can they perform well in math, science, or any other subject? Our research presents an argument for integrating math and science instruction to mesh math and science concepts and vocabulary across every grade level. This work will rocket your instruction with math concepts and vocabulary that improve your understanding of the academic language.

10:30 AM-11:30 AM
BREAKOUT
SESSION II Salon B
Research Papers

Capturing Efficiencies through Artificial Intelligence: AI for State and Local Governments

John Sutherlin
University of Louisiana Monroe

Artificial intelligence (AI) continues to cause concern, ranging from fear and alarm to jubilation, depending on the sector. For state and local governments, there is an opportunity to engage various AI platforms to assist with obligations faced by any public administrator. Whether the area is budget management, human resources, or procurement obligations, AI offers an opportunity for state and local governments to increase services, lower costs, and improve efficiency. This paper will review each of the administrative functions, determine if there are opportunities for improved efficiencies, and provide case studies for each. Then, focus will be given to other areas that may have an AI application while raising questions about the overall usage.

Salmon and Cattle Coexist in Oregon Estuaries as Collaborative Partners Reflect upon Eleanor Ostrom's Governance Scheme

Daniel Nuckols
Austin College

Various natural and human factors have adversely affected watersheds and estuaries, harming both ecosystems and economies. Unions of diverse partners address these negative impacts through conservation and restoration methods, often with negligible state influence over these partners' identification of ecosystem damages, reclamation strategies, or their governance schemes. Eleanor Ostrom identified global cases where successful non-state governance of common-pool resources exists, yet is generally dependent on core design principles. Seven participating alliances are currently addressing the ecological and farmland damage brought about by failing tide gates in the commons of the Coquille estuary, known as Winter Lake, in southern Oregon. The agency of individuals and groups depends upon their perceptions of their own successful governance of the commons, and, therefore, is crucial to the revitalization of ecosystems and economies.

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11:45 AM-1:00 PM

LUNCHEON **Atrium**

1:10 PM-2:10 PM

BREAKOUT
SESSION III
Salon A
Research Papers

Beyond the Silo: Preparing Educators to Support Gifted Learners through MTSS

Debbie Troxclair
Lamar University

This presentation introduces the MTSS+Gifted Module, a curriculum innovation designed to address two critical gaps in graduate educator preparation programs: the lack of training in Multi-Tiered Systems of Support (MTSS) and the persistent neglect of gifted learners' needs. While MTSS is widely implemented in K–12 settings to support all students through data-driven, tiered interventions, its application to gifted and twice-exceptional learners remains underdeveloped. Simultaneously, most educator preparation programs—both undergraduate and graduate—fail to provide adequate instruction on gifted education, leaving future educators ill-equipped to differentiate instruction for high-ability students.

Utilizing a Community-Based Participatory Research (CBPR) Approach to Implement a Resiliency Educational Intervention in a Multi-Disaster Community

Jill Killough & Jennifer Simmons
Lamar University

Non-profit foodservice organization employees play a unique and vital role in providing essential services to vulnerable populations within a community. Disaster preparedness for foodservice operations can contribute to efficient food production and minimize food safety concerns in perilous times. Non-profit foodservice organization employees within the upper Gulf Coast Southeast Texas region have experienced multiple disasters for several years. This project aimed to develop an educational training method utilizing the community-based participatory method and a product tailored to meet the needs of non-profit foodservice organization employees to support their continued efforts in disaster preparedness. A mixed-methods design was utilized with a pre-post educational intervention. The results indicate that non-profit organization employees in a multi-disaster community value training in disaster management and planning.

1:10 PM-2:10 PM
BREAKOUT

SESSION III
Salon B
Research Papers

Raising Geography Student Performance in Upper-Level Classes

Timothy Bailey
Pittsburg State University

Challenges related to open-ended student learning and individual assessment from group activities are presented, concluding with issues we attempt to resolve.

What About Wolf Ridge

David Wallace
The Sequoyah Group

This paper presentation aims to provide findings from a case study analysis related to these areas of interest. The findings offer insights and implications for consideration by university faculty for planning and implementing educator preparation programs that focus on instructional practices related to project-based learning in schools. This paper presentation provides findings relevant to: (1) knowledge and understanding of implementing PBL, (2) coherence in the school's enabling environment to support and sustain an innovation like PBL, and (3) assessment and evaluation of student progress on desired learning outcomes.

2:15 PM-2:25 PM Cookie BREAK

2:30 PM-3:30 PM
BREAKOUT

SESSION III
Salon A
Research Papers

Implementing CBPR Approaches for Reducing Health Disparities In Rural and Underserved Communities

Praphul Joshi
Sam Houston State University

This presentation will outline the principles of Community-Based Participatory Research (CBPR) in designing and implementing public health initiatives to address health disparities in rural and underserved areas. Examples from ongoing projects in Texas will be utilized to demonstrate the techniques used.

Prevalence of Diabetes, Cardiovascular Disease, and Cancer Among U.S. Adults who Use E-Cigarettes or Both E-Cigarettes and Conventional Cigarettes: NHANES 2017–2020

Kiran Sapkota
Sam Houston State University

Prevalence of Diabetes, Cardiovascular Disease, and Cancer Among U.S. Adults who Use E-Cigarettes or Both E-Cigarettes and Conventional Cigarettes: NHANES 2017–2020. Data were obtained from the 2017–March 2020 pre-pandemic National Health and Nutrition Examination Survey (NHANES). Adults aged ≥18 years were included. Current e-cigarette use was defined as past 5-day use, and current cigarette smoking was based on self-reported smoking status. Outcomes were self-reported diabetes, CVD (congestive heart failure, coronary heart disease, angina, myocardial infarction, or stroke), and cancer. Analyses incorporated sample weights and survey design, with logistic regression adjusting for age, sex, race/ethnicity, education, and poverty-income ratio.

Socio-behavioral Predictors of Non-Melanoma Skin Cancer in Texan Adults

Samantha Hansen Kiran Sapkota
Sam Houston State University

Introduction: Skin cancer represents a growing public health burden in the United States, particularly among fair-skinned populations. While ultraviolet (UV) exposure is the primary environmental risk factor, behavioral and occupational exposures may also contribute to non-melanoma skin cancer (NMSC) prevalence. This study explores potential relationships between demographic and behavioral variables (including age, smoker status, and history of military service) and self-reported NMSC in a representative sample of Texas adults. Methods: Cross-sectional data were drawn from the 2022 and 2023 Texas Behavioral Risk Factor Surveillance System (BRFSS), yielding a combined sample of 24,304 non-institutionalized adults. Core variables included

NMSC history, age, smoker status, and veteran status. Descriptive statistics, independent t-tests, and chi-square tests were conducted using SPSS to identify significant associations. Results: Approximately 9.6% of respondents reported a diagnosis of NMSC. Individuals with NMSC were significantly older than those without ($M = 71.2$ vs. 52.3 years, $p < .001$), with a large effect size (Cohen's $d = 1.046$). A significant association was also observed between smoking status and NMSC diagnosis ($\chi^2(3) = 146.72$, $p < .001$). However, no significant relationship was found between veteran status and NMSC history ($\chi^2(1) = 0.37$, $p = .544$). Conclusions: Age and smoking behavior were significantly associated with NMSC prevalence, while veteran status did not have significant predictive power. These findings reinforce the need for targeted prevention strategies focused on older adults and individuals with a history of tobacco use. Future multivariable models incorporating proxy measures of occupational sun exposure may inform equitable interventions.

NSSA RESEARCH SEMINARS PRESENTATION SESSION

2:30 PM-3:30 PM
BREAKOUT
SESSION III
Salon B

Integrating the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) into the Social Science Curriculum

Catherine Hooey
Pittsburg State University

It is common for sustainable development to be framed solely as an environment-focused concept founded in the earth sciences when, in fact, it is the integration of environmental, economic, and social equity goals in decision-making. The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development contains seventeen Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and was adopted by the United Nations in 2015 to serve as objectives to achieve "peace and prosperity for people and the planet" (https://sdgs.un.org/goals). The social science curriculum can play a vital role in teaching students about sustainable development and how social inequity issues, such as poverty, hunger, health/wellbeing, and gender inequality, as framed by the SDGs, can help us move toward a more sustainable world. This paper examines the role of the social science curriculum in furthering the understanding of sustainable development and its many challenges. It suggests approaches that might be used to achieve this.

The Impact of Civic Engagement on Trump Administration's Foreign Policy

Olusoji Akomolafe

Norfolk State University

American foreign policy has traditionally been shaped by elites, with minimal public participation. Under the Trump Administration, while the president pursued the "America First" agenda through executive action, civic actors—such as citizens, NGOs, courts, and advocacy groups—have influenced, challenged, and sometimes limited his policies. This paper analyzes how public engagement has acted as a check on unilateralism, keeping alternative foreign policy perspectives alive. Ultimately, it argues that foreign policy should be democratized and reflect public input, not just elite interests, through ongoing activism and advocacy.

From Mentee to Mentor: Navigating a Career in Academics

Whitney Gass
Southern Arkansas University

The journey of a career as a college professor is characterized by a multifaceted progression that blends intellectual pursuit, teaching expertise, and institutional service. This pathway typically begins with advanced graduate training, where individuals cultivate research competencies, subject matter expertise, and an initial professional identity under the guidance of mentors. Early career stages often involve postdoctoral or adjunct roles, which serve as transitions between graduate education and tenure-track appointments. During these formative years, mentorship is central, as novice academics learn scholarly practices and professional ethics from senior colleagues. Once in a faculty position, professors must balance scholarship, pedagogy, and service while gradually shifting from mentee to mentor. In this role, they guide graduate students, undergraduate researchers, and junior faculty, extending the cycle of academic growth. Securing tenure and promotion represents a milestone and recognition of contributions in research, teaching, mentorship, and service. Beyond tenure, professors refine their research agendas, expand teaching expertise, and often assume leadership roles within departments or professional organizations. Despite challenges such as heavy workloads and shifting institutional demands, the profession offers opportunities for lifelong learning, personal fulfillment, and societal impact through education and research. The progression from mentee to mentor highlights the cyclical and generative nature of academic life, emphasizing how guidance received in early stages evolves into the responsibility of fostering future scholars. This trajectory underscores the interplay between personal ambition, scholarly contribution, and the evolving landscape of higher education.

RESEARCH SEMINARS PRESENTATION SESSION
3:40 PM - 5:00 PM BREAKOUT SESSION
SESSION IV

Salon A

The Unseen Hand: The Social Worker's Role in End-of-Life Care

Cortney Sherman
Southern Arkansas University

The multifaceted process of end-of-life care requires a holistic approach, but often only medical professionals are examined despite the collaboration of an interdisciplinary team. While the roles of the physicians and nurses are essential to the dying process, the social, emotional, and familial resources are just as vital to the patient and their families. Social workers' unique skillsets help make the end-of-life journey's complexities less stressful and more peaceful. The focus here is to define and examine the critical role of the social worker within the interdisciplinary, palliative, and hospice care teams. This presentation argues that social workers' contributions are fundamental to achieving a peaceful and dignified end-of-life experience. Ultimately, the goal is to shed light on the "unseen hand" of the social worker while asserting that the social worker is an invaluable component of the end-of-life team and is essential in providing compassionate, high-quality end-of-life care.

The Impact of Fear of Failure on the Impostor Phenomenon

Krista Nelson
Southern Arkansas University

The concept of the Impostor Phenomenon (IP) as a theory has been trending for several years. The term, coined by Pauline Rose Clance and Suzanne Imes in the 1970s, identified an experience that can negatively impact an individual's self-esteem and feelings of self-worth. The impostor phenomenon is an experience in which an individual believes their personal successes result from luck or chance, or "being in the right place at the right time," and does not believe that their accomplishments result from their personal intelligence or capabilities. A person suffering from the impostor phenomenon believes that even though they are successful, their accomplishments result from a "fluke" or some other external circumstance. This presentation will expound on the characteristics of the impostor phenomenon and explain how fear of failure can intensify IP development. Treatment options to assist individuals displaying impostor phenomenon traits will be discussed.

Advancing AI Literacy from a Global Perspective

Benita Bruster, Barry Bruster & Joe Elarde
Austin Peay State University

This presentation explores global approaches to Artificial Intelligence (AI) literacy, focusing on China, India, the United States, and Russia. Each country has launched explicit plans to integrate AI education across K–12, higher education, workforce development, and public awareness. China and Russia pursue highly centralized strategies with strong state-led implementation, while India and the U.S. combine national direction with local or state-level execution. India stands out for embedding AI in the CBSE curriculum and public campaigns, while the U.S. emphasizes federal guidance, university fluency programs, and workforce readiness. This session proposes a U.S. course correction: setting measurable literacy goals, expanding teacher training, and launching nationwide public micro-learning opportunities. The presentation highlights comparative strengths, gaps, and pathways to establish U.S. leadership in AI literacy.

RESEARCH ROUNDTABLE SESSION
3:40 PM-4:40 PM BREAKOUT SESSION
SESSION IV
Salon B

Faux Math

Barba Aldis Patton & Teresa LeSage Clements
TAMU-Victoria

Students need to learn and be able to use mathematical language, or we will not see improvement in student math achievement. NAEP (2025) data indicate that most students are experiencing difficulties in math. This issue is worsening each year. Mathematical language should be incorporated into everyday instruction to equip students with the skills necessary to compete globally. Join our roundtable to explore how the current trend of some teachers using faux math and not mathematical language may hinder our students' math success.

Challenges and Successes of Teaching Demography to Undergraduates

Marisa Sanchez
California State University, Bakersfield

An undergraduate demography course can be perceived as challenging to students. In my eleven years of experience teaching demography at California State University, Bakersfield, student feedback highlighted two main challenges. Demography is a scientific discipline within the social sciences, often housed within sociology programs, which means many undergraduates only take one demography course in their undergraduate careers. Hence, students report frequently feeling overwhelmed by the newness and unfamiliarity of demographic theories, concepts, and measures. This paper attempts to address these two challenges through two instructional practices:

incorporating a flipped classroom model and in-depth lessons on writing about numbers/data into the course curriculum.

Integrating Emotional Intelligence and Cultural Intelligence in Professional Development for K-12 Teachers Working with Multilingual Learners: A Systematic Design Approach

Viktoria Korogodsky, Jillian R. Powers, Susanne Lapp, & Eileen Ariza
Florida Atlantic University

K-12 teachers face complex challenges that require more than traditional pedagogical training in multilingual and multicultural educational environments. This roundtable session presents an instructional module that integrates Emotional Intelligence (EQ) and Cultural Intelligence (CQ) as essential competencies for effective teaching of multilingual learners (MLs). Developed using the Dick and Carey systematic instructional design model, this professional development instructional module addresses a critical gap in teacher preparation through evidence-based design principles. Following this approach, the module development included a comprehensive needs analysis of K-12 teacher competencies, clear performance objectives linking EQ and CQ skills to classroom effectiveness, and criterion-referenced assessment tools. During the roundtable, the presenters share the module development process and the module itself, and they seek feedback from the academic community on the module's design, theoretical integration, and practical applications.

TUESDAY, October 21st, 2025

8:00 am-9:00 am	**Registration**	**(in Front of Salons A & B)**
7:00 am-9:00 am	**Breakfast**	**Atrium**
9:00 am-12:00 pm	**Virtual Presentations**	**Salons A & B**

ALL NSSA VIRTUAL SESSIONS ON Tuesday, OCTOBER 21, 2025
9:00 am-11:00 am

Virtual Research Presentations
9:00 AM-10:00 AM SESSION
Salon A
Virtual Session Chair, Praphul Joshi
Join Zoom Meeting
https://us04web.zoom.us/j/76698378686?pwd=RJQ7Fw3EBjEVbzp76VvfdJPLOPVGsy.1

Virtual Research Presentations 9:00 am-10:00 am

Salon A
Zoom Link:
https://us04web.zoom.us/j/76698378686?pwd=RJQ7Fw3EBjEVbzp76VvfdJPLOPVGsy.1

Effective Meeting Strategies for Leaders of Hybrid Videoconferencing

Kim McGarraugh Jones
Central Washington University

Prior to the COVID pandemic, businesses and universities were already taking advantage of the benefits of offering video conferencing as an option for meetings. It can be convenient since members can join from anywhere and access the Internet. Telecommuting can save a company the costs of attendees' transportation and can be preferred because it allows for AI note summaries, transcription, and recordings. During the COVID pandemic, videoconferencing became mandatory for companies wishing to continue business. Businesses had to determine which platform would best meet their needs; many are choosing to continue offering videoconferencing as an option for employees. This presentation will discuss hybrid meeting leaders' responsibilities that can facilitate more effective meetings in which all participants do not experience meeting inequity and proximity bias. The presentation concludes with a checklist that hybrid meeting leaders can access when preparing for meetings.

Teacher Use of Metacognitive Practices in AP Programs Research

Ron Childress & Melissa Alexander-Blythe
Marshall University

Metacognition, or thinking about your thinking and learning, was formally recognized and labeled some 50 years ago. The concept has been extensively studied over the years, with results suggesting it is an effective approach to learning. The underlying premise is that if you develop an awareness of how you think and learn, you can use metacognitive strategies to facilitate more effective learning. Despite this evidence of a positive impact on learning, metacognitive strategies have not been consistently used in advanced high school curricula. This presentation will present findings from a class project investigating using metacognitive strategies in advanced courses in high and low SES high schools. Recommendations will be provided.

Virtual Research Presentations 9:00 am-10:00 am

Salon B
Virtual Session Chair
Benita Bruster
Zoom Meeting Link: https://apsu.zoom.us/j/91440399362

9:00 AM-10:00 AM SESSION I
Salon B

Teaching the Teachers: Can AI Build Better Support Plans from Human Insight?
Research

Shelly Allen, Frances Perez, Darryl Ann Borel
Lamar University

As schools face mounting pressure to retain and support educators, intervention planning for struggling teachers has become a critical focus for instructional leaders. This session explores how artificial intelligence (AI) can enhance the clarity, consistency, and impact of teacher support plans when guided by human insight. Drawing from a qualitative study of graduate students in a teacher leadership program, the presentation examines how candidates used AI tools to develop personalized coaching strategies, scaffold lesson materials, and generate differentiated instructional suggestions. Attendees will leave with practical strategies for integrating AI into teacher intervention workflows, sample tools for refining teacher support plans, and a deeper understanding of how technology can amplify, not replace, the human elements of teacher development.

Older Adults' Perceptions of Physical Activity Programs in a Local Senior Center: The Role of Fall History

Mihae Bae & Hyunsook Kang
Stephen F Austin State University

The study examined older adults' perceptions of physical activity programs offered at a local senior center. An IRB-approved survey was distributed to program participants, with 57 responses analyzed (4 males; 53 females), ranging in age from 65 to 90 years.. Findings revealed a mixed pattern of results among participants with a history of falls or near-falls. ANOVA results indicated that fall history significantly predicted lower confidence in exercising independently, explaining approximately 25% of the variance in confidence scores ($F(1, 55) = 17.99$, $p < .001$). In contrast, correlation analyses indicated that participants with fall histories reported greater overall exercise confidence ($r = .50$, $p < .001$) and higher satisfaction with exercise programs ($r = .35$, $p = .007$), with fall history accounting for 12% of the variance in satisfaction ($F(1,55) = 7.73$, $p = .007$). These results suggest that while current programs are valued and appreciated by older adults with fall histories, program design may not fully address their maximum needs.

Research Virtual Roundtables & Seminars

10:00 AM-11:30 AM SESSION
Salon A

Virtual Session Chair, Praphul Joshi
Zoom Meeting Link:
https://us04web.zoom.us/j/76698378686?pwd=RJQ7Fw3EBjEVbzp76VvfdJPLOPVGsy.1

Supporting Teachers: A Collaborative Model of Multi-Tiered System of Supports (MTSS)

Yan Yan & Thomas W Harvey
Lamar University

The session will present key qualitative themes, discuss implications for practice, and provide recommendations for replicating this model of graduate-led professional development in diverse educational settings. By bridging theory, preparation, and practice, this research illustrates how collaborative, schoolwide approaches to MTSS can strengthen instructional coherence, expand educator capacity, and advance equity and success for all students.

Addressing and Managing Aberrant Behavior among Emergent Bilinguals In General Education Environments

Charmaine Lowe & Ling Wang
Austin Peay State University

Considering emergent bilinguals' adaptive processes, ways of facilitating English Language Learner (ELL) students' transitions and adjustments to mainstream United States (U.S.) schooling contexts are uncovered by understanding and effectively addressing subversive classroom behaviors. Identifying fundamental elements of classroom management while maintaining focus on the unique dynamics affected by linguistic diversity among student bodies remains crucial. The stages of cultural adaptation and related pedagogical strategies, emphasizing the creation of affirming classroom climates, should be considered when sculpting classroom climates. Facilitating the construction of a strong sense of community for those instructing or preparing pre-service teachers to instruct linguistically-diverse students, as well as to equip those same professionals and pre-service professionals to address forms of oppositional behavior that most commonly arise among English Language Learners, remains imperative in U.S. classrooms.

The Role of Culture in Sustainable Development:

Global Perspectives from India

Evelyne Delgado-Norris
Chicago State University

It has long been recognized and now highlighted by the United Nations in their efforts for sustainable development worldwide that culture is an essential component in development strategies and a driving force for progress and creative solutions.
The presentation will draw on aspects explored during a 2025 CAORC faculty development fellowship in India to highlight three facets of culture in sustainable development: Culture and Education as Foundations of Sustainability, Culture as Catalyst for Creativity, and Women, Culture, and Sustainable Development.
*CAORC is "Council of American Overseas Research Centers"

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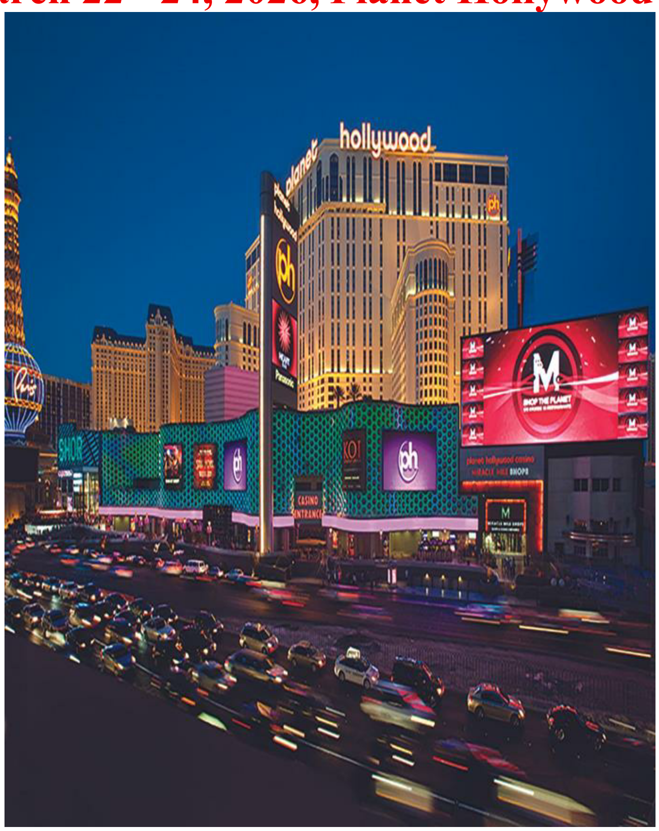

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NSSA is offering a "Student Paper Competition" at the conference. Graduate and undergraduate students are encouraged to submit a paper and attend the conference. The scoring rubric and paper expectations are located at https://nssascholars.org/student-paper-competition/. Papers will be eligible for peer-review process to be published in the National Social Science Journal.

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*The abstract is to be in fully justified italicized text, as it is here, below the author's information. Use the word "Abstract" as the title, in 12-point Ariel or Times New Roman, boldface type, centered relative to the column, initially capitalized. The abstract should be in 12-point, single-spaced type and up to 250 words. Leave two blank lines after the abstract to add the keywords, then leave two blank lines to begin the main text. *The submission cannot have been previously published nor submitted to another journal for consideration simultaneously.*

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Fostering Equity and Excellence: A Teaching Philosophy for Advanced Academics

Melissa Alexander-Blythe

Marshall Univeristy

CI 704

Dr. Huanshu Yuan

April 20, 2024

Introduction

As an educator committed to fostering inclusive learning environments and promoting educational equity, my teaching philosophy is rooted in the belief that education can transform lives and communities. Drawing on critical pedagogical perspectives such as Paulo Freire's "Pedagogy of the Oppressed" (Freire, 2017) and bell hooks' "Teaching to Transgress" (hooks, 1994), I recognize the importance of centering students' voices, experiences, and identities in the educational process. By creating spaces where students feel empowered to question, critique, and reimagine the world around them, I aim to create a culture of critical inquiry, empathy, and social responsibility in classrooms. Through intentional efforts to address systemic inequities and promote inclusive practices, I strive to help create learning environments where all students have the opportunity to thrive and realize their full potential.

Literature Review

Access to advanced coursework has been a longstanding issue in education, with persisting disparities in participation rates among students from different demographic backgrounds. Drawing on critical pedagogical perspectives such as Paulo Freire's "Pedagogy of the Oppressed," educators have highlighted the transformative potential of education in challenging oppressive systems and fostering liberation. Freire'sl work emphasizes the importance of conscientização, or critical consciousness, in empowering marginalized communities to critically analyze and transform oppressive social structures. By applying Freire's principles to educational contexts, educators can create learning environments that not only impart knowledge but also cultivate critical thinking skills and empower students to become agents of change. Indeed, advanced academics can serve as a powerful tool for liberation, providing marginalized students with the knowledge and skills needed to challenge inequities and advocate for social justice in their communities.

"Teaching to Transgress" by bell hooks offers insights into the potential of education to liberate and dismantle dominant paradigms and fostering inclusive learning environments.

hooks advocates for a pedagogy of love and liberation that centers on the holistic development of students as critical thinkers and agents of social change. By engaging students in dialogue, critical reflection, and experiential learning, educators can create spaces where students feel empowered to question, critique, and reimagine the world around them. In this way, advanced academics can serve as a vehicle for personal and collective liberation, enabling students to transcend societal limitations and envision new possibilities for themselves and their communities.

In addition to critical pedagogical perspectives, research has explored the impact of participation in Advanced Placement (AP) programs on various student outcomes, including college admissions test scores and enrollment in four-year colleges. Chajewski, Mattern, and Shaw (2015) investigated the role of AP exam participation in students' college admissions test scores, providing valuable insights into the relationship between rigorous academic preparation and academic readiness for postsecondary education. Their findings suggested that students who participated in AP programs tended to achieve higher college admissions test scores, indicating the benefits of engaging in challenging coursework during high school. By providing access to advanced academics, educators can empower students to pursue higher education and pursue their aspirations, thereby expanding opportunities for personal and social advancement.

Kolluri (2011) examined the impact of AP exam participation on four-year college enrollment rates, shedding light on the relationship between AP coursework and students' postsecondary pathways. Through an analysis of educational data, Kolluri identified a significant association between AP exam participation and increased likelihood of four-year college enrollment for students. These findings underscored the importance of providing equitable access to advanced academic programs, such as AP courses, to promote college readiness and academic success for all students, particularly those from historically underserved communities. By dismantling barriers to access and promoting inclusive practices, educators can create pathways to higher education and economic mobility for marginalized students, thereby contributing to a more equitable and just society.

Addressing equity gaps in access to advanced coursework is not only a matter of social justice but also a strategic imperative for educational excellence and workforce development. Research suggests that diverse learning environments benefit all students by fostering critical thinking, creativity, and problem-solving skills (American Progress, n.d.). By promoting diversity and inclusivity in advanced coursework, we can enrich the educational experience for all students and better prepare them for success in an increasingly diverse and interconnected world.

Kolluri (2011) addressed the challenge of equal access and effectiveness in AP programs, highlighting the dual nature of ensuring both equitable participation and positive outcomes for students. By examining the factors influencing unequal participation in AP coursework, Kolluri shed light on the complex dynamics of access and opportunity in advanced academic settings. The study emphasized the need for targeted interventions and leadership practices to address opportunity gaps and promote equitable access to advanced coursework for marginalized students. Through intentional efforts to address systemic inequities and promote inclusive practices, educators can create learning environments where all students have the opportunity to thrive and realize their full potential.

Similarly, Andreoli (2023) conducted a multiple case study exploring principals' perceptions of opportunity gaps and their leadership practices in addressing access to AP courses for marginalized students. The study provided valuable insights into the barriers and challenges school leaders face in promoting equitable access to advanced academic opportunities. Through an in-depth analysis of principals' perceptions and practices, Andreoli highlighted the importance of leadership in addressing systemic inequities and fostering a culture of inclusive excellence in schools. By prioritizing equity and inclusion in educational leadership practices, administrators can create school climates where all students feel valued, supported, and empowered to succeed.

Philosophy

Foundations of Pedagogy

Layered and complex experiences and ideas inform my teaching approach of theoretical frameworks, educational philosophies, and best practices. I draw inspiration from social justice pedagogy, culturally responsive teaching, and metacognitive development (Scott & Lee, 2019), among others. I believe in the importance of creating learning experiences that are relevant, meaningful, and engaging for students from diverse backgrounds. I strive to create a supportive and inclusive learning environment where all students feel valued, respected, and empowered to succeed. Differentiation is key to meeting the diverse needs of learners, and I regularly incorporate a variety of instructional strategies to accommodate different learning styles and abilities. I am committed to fostering a culture of excellence, collaboration, and lifelong learning in my classroom, where students are encouraged to take risks, ask questions, and explore their passions.

Equitable Access to Advanced Academics

I am deeply committed to ensuring equitable access to advanced academic programs for all students, liike Advanced Placement (AP) courses. Research on the impact of participation in AP programs (Chajewski et al., 2015; Kolluri, 2011) underscores the importance of rigorous coursework in preparing students for postsecondary education and fostering critical thinking skills. I am dedicated to breaking down barriers and expanding opportunities for historically underserved student populations, including low-income students, students of color, and students with disabilities. Every student deserves access to high-quality instruction and challenging academic opportunities, regardless of their background or circumstances.

Instructional Practices

In my work, I prioritize student-centered instruction that promotes active engagement, collaboration, and inquiry-based learning. Differentiation is key to meeting the diverse needs of learners, and I regularly incorporate a variety of instructional strategies to accommodate different learning styles and abilities. Drawing on insights from critical pedagogical perspectives (Freire, 2017; hooks, 1994), I strive to help create a supportive and inclusive learning environment where all students feel valued, respected, and empowered to succeed. I am committed to fostering a culture of excellence, collaboration, and lifelong learning in the classrooms I support, where students are encouraged to take risks, ask questions, and explore their passions.

Culturally Responsive Teaching

Cultural responsiveness is foundational to my teaching philosophy, as I firmly believe in the importance of recognizing, valuing, and affirming the diverse identities, backgrounds, and experiences of all students. Drawing upon critical pedagogical perspectives such as Paulo Freire's "Pedagogy of the Oppressed" (Freire, 2017) and bell hooks' "Teaching to Transgress" (hooks, 1994), I am deeply committed to creating learning environments that foster inclusivity, empathy, and social justice. In my classroom, I strive to cultivate a sense of belonging and agency among students, empowering them to critically engage with course content and challenge dominant narratives.

To achieve this, I intentionally design curriculum and instructional practices that center on students' lived experiences and cultural contexts. I incorporate diverse perspectives, voices, and texts into the curriculum, ensuring that students see themselves reflected in their learning materials and have opportunities to explore topics from multiple viewpoints. Through literature, discussions, and experiential learning activities, I encourage students to critically examine power, privilege, and oppression issues, fostering a deeper understanding of societal inequities and their impact on individuals and communities.

Moreover, I prioritize the development of critical consciousness and social responsibility among my students. Inspired by Freire's concept of *conscientização*, I engage students in dialogue and reflection to deepen their awareness of social injustices and inspire them to take action for positive change. This is not only the work of dismantling oppressive systems, but it is metacogntive in its approach. By helping create safe and supportive learning environments where students feel empowered to express their perspectives, ask difficult questions, and challenge conventional wisdom, I aim to support systemic efforts in cultivating a culture of critical inquiry and transformative praxis.

In alignment with hooks' notion of education as the practice of freedom, I view teaching as a collaborative and reciprocal process that honors students' agency and expertise. I actively listen to students' voices, incorporating their feedback and insights into the co-construction of knowledge. Through supporting the development of collaborative projects, group discussions, and peer-to-peer learning experiences, I help foster a sense of community and mutual respect among students, valuing their contributions as co-creators of knowledge.

My approach to culturally responsive teaching is grounded in the belief that education has the power to transform lives and create a more just and equitable society. By drawing upon critical pedagogical perspectives and centering students' identities and experiences, I strive to help teachers create learning environments where all students feel seen, heard, and valued. Through intentional efforts to promote inclusivity, empathy, and social justice, I aim to empower students to become critical thinkers, compassionate leaders, and agents of positive change in their communities and beyond.

Conclusion

My teaching philosophy is centered on the principles of equity, excellence, and inclusivity. I am dedicated to creating learning environments where all students feel valued, supported, and challenged to reach their highest potential. By fostering a culture of curiosity, critical thinking, and social responsibility, I aim to empower students to become lifelong learners and agents of change in their communities and beyond.

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Curriculum as Art and Empowerment: An Integrated Framework Drawing on Eisner and Freire

Melissa Alexander-Blythe

CI 702

Marshall University

Introduction

In today's complex educational landscape, the reality of high-stakes testing and standards-based assessments, the drive for rigor and alignment can take a toll on the students and the education system at large. Much of today's curriculum is driven by laws, state requirements, and fierce competition for funding, leaving little room for student expression and creativity.

Eisner and Freire, while at the outset appearing different, actually share commonality in their foundational purviews of self-expression and individuality. Eisner takes the unique view that curriculum serves as the vehicle for aesthetics and imagination while critiquing the need for uniform measures of success. Freire focuses on curriculum as a means for political and social change, challenging the status quo and creating social activists. The incorporation of these two ideas creates something unique and powerful: curriculum as a way to make change, but a way to create beauty while making change and empowering others. This paper explores the idea of a new curriculum, one that blends Freire and Eisner's views creating something unique, a curriculum where students not only create beauty through self-expression and learning but also become vehicles for change and political movement.

Literature Review on Curriculum Theories

Curriculum as Artistic and Political

Curriculum, often viewed through the lens of standardized content and rigid assessments, holds the potential to be both a creative and empowering space for students. Elliot Eisner and Paulo Freire provide two complementary frameworks that redefine the purpose of curriculum, challenging traditional approaches that prioritize rigid assessment and factual knowledge over holistic student development. Together, their theories advocate for a curriculum that balances creativity with critical engagement, positioning advanced academic programs as platforms for intellectual and social empowerment (Andrews, 1989; Giroux, 1985).

Eisner's concept of education as an artistic endeavor aligns with Freire's critical pedagogy by emphasizing both individual expression and societal impact. Eisner (2002) argues that curriculum should be treated as an aesthetic experience, designed to evoke creativity and invite students to make personal connections with content. Freire (2000), meanwhile, frames curriculum as a tool for liberation, enabling students to critically examine societal structures and their role within them. These perspectives challenge the conventional, content-driven view of curriculum by promoting an integrated approach where students engage deeply with both the material and the broader context of their learning (Roberts, 2000).

Curriculum as Art and Self-Expression

Elliot Eisner's vision of curriculum challenges traditional notions of education as rigid and outcomes-driven, proposing instead that curriculum should evoke creativity and provide opportunities for personal expression. Eisner (2002) argues that aesthetic experiences in education allow students to connect with content in meaningful and transformative ways. This approach is particularly valuable in advanced academic settings, where students are often asked to engage with abstract concepts and complex material. By incorporating creativity and self-expression into the curriculum, educators can make challenging content more accessible and engaging for students (Eisner, 1985; Rolling, 2010).

In practice, Eisner's aesthetic framework might manifest in assignments that invite students to approach academic material through artistic interpretation. For instance, in an AP English Literature class, students could analyze the thematic elements of a novel by creating visual or multimedia projects that reflect their understanding of the text. Such tasks align with Eisner's belief that education should honor diverse modes of learning and expression, encouraging students to explore their unique perspectives while mastering academic content (Eisner, 1994; Mahmoudi et al., 2014).

The emphasis on self-expression also supports the metacognitive development of advanced academic students. Rolling (2010) highlights the role of arts-based educational practices in fostering critical awareness and reflective thinking, skills that are essential for success in rigorous academic programs. When students are encouraged to reflect on their creative processes and the decisions they make during learning activities, they develop a deeper understanding of their cognitive abilities and personal growth.

Eisner's aesthetic principles are particularly significant in promoting equity and inclusion in advanced academic programs. For students from underserved communities, curriculum that values creativity and personal expression can provide a sense of agency and belonging. Greene (1995) argues that imagination in education allows students to envision possibilities beyond their immediate circumstances, empowering them to articulate their experiences and aspirations. By incorporating Eisner's framework into advanced academic curricula, educators can create learning environments that challenge students intellectually while also validating their identities and perspectives.

Curriculum as Empowerment and Social Change

While Eisner focuses on the individual and artistic dimensions of education, Paulo Freire emphasizes the collective and transformative power of curriculum. Freire (1985) argues that education is inherently political and that curriculum should enable students to critically analyze and challenge the social structures that shape their lives. His concept of "conscientização" positions curriculum as a tool for fostering critical consciousness, equipping students to become active participants in their communities (Giroux, 1985; Roberts, 2000).

In advanced academic settings, Freire's ideas are particularly relevant for addressing the needs of marginalized students. Traditional curricula often fail to reflect the lived experiences of these students, perpetuating a sense of alienation and exclusion. Freirean pedagogy challenges this deficit-based approach by advocating for curriculum that is culturally responsive and socially relevant. McLaren (2000) explains that by integrating students' cultural identities into the learning process, educators can create environments where students feel validated and empowered to succeed.

For example, an AP Government course could include projects that examine local policy issues through the lens of equity and justice, encouraging students to connect academic content with real-world challenges. Similarly, an AP Environmental Science class might require students to investigate environmental injustices in their communities, combining scientific analysis with advocacy. These activities align with Freire's belief that education should inspire students to recognize their agency and take action on societal issues.

Freire's emphasis on empowerment also aligns with culturally relevant pedagogy, which seeks to make curriculum meaningful by connecting it to students' cultural experiences and values. Ladson-Billings (1995) highlights the importance of designing assignments that allow students to draw on their backgrounds as resources for learning. By incorporating critical pedagogy into advanced academic programs, educators can create curricula that are both rigorous and inclusive, fostering a sense of ownership and purpose among students.

Through the integration of Freirean principles, curriculum becomes a means of preparing students for both academic achievement and social responsibility. By positioning students as active participants in their education, this model challenges the conventional notion of advanced academics as a purely academic endeavor, reframing it as a platform for intellectual and civic engagement.

Personal Theory of Curriculum

Integrating Eisner and Freire: Toward a Dual Framework

The theories of Eisner and Freire converge in their shared commitment to creating meaningful, inclusive, and transformative educational experiences. Eisner's emphasis on creativity and personal expression complements Freire's focus on social critique and empowerment, offering a dual framework that redefines the purpose of curriculum in advanced academic settings. By blending these perspectives, educators can design programs that challenge students intellectually while also fostering a sense of purpose and agency.

This integrated approach positions curriculum as both an artistic and political space, where students are encouraged to think critically and authentically express themselves. Assignments that incorporate creative interpretation and critical analysis, such as multimedia projects exploring historical inequities or reflective essays on contemporary social issues, demonstrate the potential of this model to engage students on multiple levels. In doing so, such curricula not only prepare students for academic success but also equip them to navigate and influence the world beyond the classroom.

The Synthesis of Art and Empowerment in Curriculum

My personal theory of curriculum integrates the complementary perspectives of Elliot Eisner and Paulo Freire, emphasizing the importance of creativity, personal expression, and social empowerment. This synthesis positions curriculum as both an artistic and political space, where students are encouraged to develop their unique voices while critically engaging with the structures that shape their lives. By blending Eisner's aesthetic approach with Freire's critical pedagogy, I envision a curriculum that supports intellectual growth, fosters self-discovery, and equips students to contribute meaningfully to their communities (Eisner, 1985; Freire, 1985).

Eisner's concept of curriculum as an art form highlights the transformative potential of creativity in education. Through assignments that invite students to interpret content artistically, educators can create environments that value individual perspectives and diverse modes of expression (Eisner, 1994; Eisner, 2002). For example, in an advanced academic context, an AP History course might incorporate visual storytelling to explore key historical events, encouraging students to analyze the past through creative mediums such as graphic novels or digital art. These tasks honor Eisner's belief in the qualitative dimensions of learning, helping students connect deeply with material while cultivating critical thinking and problem-solving skills (Andrews, 1989).

Freire's vision of curriculum as a means of empowerment complements Eisner's artistic focus by emphasizing the societal relevance of education. In this framework, curriculum is not merely a collection of facts and procedures but a dynamic process through which students develop critical consciousness, or "conscientização" (Freire, 2000; Roberts, 2000). In advanced academic programs, this might involve assignments that challenge students to examine contemporary social issues and propose actionable solutions (Giroux, 2010).

This dual framework, grounded in Eisner's aesthetic principles and Freire's emancipatory ideals, addresses the individual and social dimensions of education, offering a holistic approach to curriculum design. In advanced academic settings, this model has the potential to transform learning into a meaningful, inclusive experience that prepares students for both academic success and civic engagement.

Conclusion

This paper has explored the integration of Elliot Eisner's and Paulo Freire's theories into a cohesive curriculum framework that balances artistic exploration and critical empowerment. By viewing curriculum as both an artistic and political space, this model redefines education as a means of fostering creativity, personal growth, and societal engagement. Eisner's emphasis on self-expression complements Freire's focus on critical consciousness, creating a holistic approach that challenges traditional, rigid educational structures.

In advanced academic settings, such a curriculum framework holds the potential to transform learning into a meaningful and inclusive experience. By incorporating Eisner's aesthetic principles, educators can design assignments that encourage students to connect with content personally and creatively. Meanwhile, Freire's focus on empowerment ensures that these connections extend beyond the classroom, inspiring students to recognize their agency and act on social challenges. Together, these perspectives offer a vision for curriculum that is not only rigorous but also culturally responsive, inclusive, and equitable.

Future research on this topic could explore how Eisner's and Freire's theories can be practically implemented in advanced academic programs, particularly in underserved schools. Examining the impact of creative, critical curricula on student engagement, achievement, and empowerment could provide valuable insights for educators and policymakers seeking to bridge gaps in equity and access. Additionally, investigating how this framework interacts with technological advancements, such as AI in education, may reveal new opportunities to enhance learning.

Ultimately, this integrated theory of curriculum affirms the transformative potential of education. By empowering students to express themselves authentically and critically engage with the world, curriculum becomes not just a pathway to academic success but also a foundation for creating thoughtful, compassionate, and active citizens. By incorporating these perspectives, educators can create advanced academic programs that inspire students to think deeply, express themselves authentically, and contribute meaningfully to their communities (Giroux, 1985; Andrews, 1989).

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